A DISSERTATION

After the Filiative Contract

The Natal Exception, Thalassic Natality, and the Humanism of the Wake in Children of Men



P. D. JAMES · THE CHILDREN OF MEN · 1992
ALFONSO CUARÓN · CHILDREN OF MEN · 2006
SCREENPLAY · CUARÓN, TIMOTHY J. SEXTON, DAVID ARATA, MARK FERGUS & HAWK OSTBY

OCTOBER 2026

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A comparative political-theological, feminist, and postcolonial reading of P. D. James, *The Children of Men* (1992), and Alfonso Cuarón, Timothy J. Sexton, David Arata, Mark Fergus and Hawk Ostby, *Children of Men* (2006)



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Abstract

THIS DISSERTATION ARGUES that *Children of Men*—read not as a source text and its adaptation but as a single diptych distributed across P. D. James's novel *The Children of Men* (1992) and the film *Children of Men* (2006), directed by Alfonso Cuarón from a screenplay credited to Cuarón, Timothy J. Sexton, David Arata, Mark Fergus and Hawk Ostby—constitutes the most exacting fictional experiment yet conducted on the hidden premise of political modernity: the assumption of posterity. Global human infertility, the premise the two works share, annuls what I term the *filiative contract*, the tacit intergenerational covenant, articulated in different idioms by Burke, Kant, Benjamin, Jonas and Scheffler, through which polities, economies, cultures and churches draw legitimacy and motive from their presumed continuation in successors. Read through political theology (Schmitt, Benjamin, Agamben), the philosophy of natality (Augustine, Arendt, Levinas), biopolitical and necropolitical theory (Foucault, Esposito, Mbembe), feminist and queer thought (Beauvoir, Firestone, Rich, Kristeva, Irigaray, Ruddick, Cavarero, Butler, Edelman, Haraway, social-reproduction theory), Black and decolonial thought (Fanon, Spillers, Wynter, Gilroy, Hartman, Sharpe) and film-philosophy (Bazin, Deleuze), the two versions emerge as antithetical responses to the contract's collapse. James's Anglican and Burkean novel *re-filiates* the future: its miraculous birth is recaptured by patrilineal sacrament and sovereign succession, culminating in a transfer of the Warden's ring whose structure is at once Frazerian and Freudian. Cuarón's film *de-filiates* it: the future is borne by a stateless West African woman of unknown paternity, delivered by a dying surrogate father, named for another man's dead son, and carried off the national territory onto the open sea.

From this comparison the dissertation derives an original theoretical apparatus. The *natal exception* names the birth, staged in the film's Bexhill ceasefire, as an exception to the sovereign state of exception: an event that suspends the friend–enemy distinction without founding a new sovereignty, and that is therefore destituent rather than constituent. *Thalassic natality* names the claim that, because sovereignty is constituted by the appropriation of land, the newcomer can be received only in a commons figured as the sea; it is developed by turning Schmitt's *Land and Sea* against itself and through Grotius's *mare liberum*, Foucault's

heterotopia, the Black Atlantic and Ferenczi's *Thalassa*. The *arrivant identity* names the structural identity, at the level of political ontology, of the newborn and the refugee, each of whom arrives without credentials into a world that precedes it; the film's decisive invention is to fuse the two in a single body. From that identity follow a *natal criterion of legitimacy*—a polity is legitimate to the degree that it can receive the newcomer without appropriating it—and a diagnosis of nativist pronatalism as political autoimmunity. Finally, the *humanism of the wake* names a post-sovereign humanism grounded in natality rather than autonomy, in reception rather than self-fashioning, in kinship made rather than inherited, and in care for a future one will not inhabit. Articulated in seven theses, it keeps the threefold sense Christina Sharpe gives the word *wake*: vigil over the dead, track of a vessel, return to consciousness. The dissertation concludes that the apocalypse of *Children of Men* discloses not an end but an address to the one who comes—the imperative, inherited from Psalm 90 and the closing verses of Revelation, to say *Come*.

Thou turnest man to destruction : again thou sayest, Come again, ye children of men.

— Psalm 90:3, *The Book of Common Prayer* (Coverdale Psalter)

In Rama was there a voice heard, lamentation, and weeping, and great mourning, Rachel weeping for her children, and would not be comforted, because they are not.

— Matthew 2:18 (Authorized Version)

La crisi consiste appunto nel fatto che il vecchio muore e il nuovo non può nascere.

[The crisis consists precisely in the fact that the old is dying and the new cannot be born.]

— Antonio Gramsci, *Quaderni del carcere*, Q3 §34 (1930)

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PREFATORY NOTE

Corpus, Authorship, Method

CORPUS The object of this study is a diptych: P. D. James, *The Children of Men* (London: Faber and Faber, 1992), and *Children of Men* (Universal Pictures, 2006), directed by Alfonso Cuarón, photographed by Emmanuel Lubezki, and credited to the writers Alfonso Cuarón & Timothy J. Sexton and David Arata and Mark Fergus & Hawk Ostby. 'The novel' and 'the film' designate these works; 'the diptych' designates their conjunction. Cuarón's companion documentary, *The Possibility of Hope* (2007), in which Slavoj Žižek, Naomi Klein, Saskia Sassen, James Lovelock, John Gray and Tzvetan Todorov reflect on the film's world, is treated as a paratext in Genette's sense (1987) rather than as an authorial key.

THE DIPTYCH HYPOTHESIS Adaptation studies has long abandoned fidelity as a criterion of value (Stam 2000; Hutcheon 2006). Hutcheon's formula for adaptation—repetition without replication—licenses the method pursued here, which treats the film neither as the novel's translation nor as its betrayal but as its dialogical antagonist in Bakhtin's sense: a second utterance that answers the first by retaining its premise and many of its names while inverting nearly every value attached to them. The relation between the two works is therefore itself an argument, and the gap between them is where that argument is made. In Genette's vocabulary (1982) the film is the novel's hypertext; it is also its critique.

AUTHORSHIP The novel has a single author. The film's screenplay credit, with its guild conventions of ampersand and conjunction, records a development history in which drafts by distinct hands were layered and revised. This distributed authorship is registered here not as a philological inconvenience but as a thematic coincidence: a work about the dissolution of lineage is itself without a single originating parent, a text of the kind Barthes (1967) described as a tissue of citations rather than the issue of an author. The title records the same movement. James's definite article—*The* Children of Men, a determinate collective, a line—disappears in the film, which names an indefinite plurality. The adaptation begins its de-filiation at the level of grammar.

METHOD Four procedures are combined: comparative political theology, which reads sovereignty, miracle and exception as secularized theological forms (Schmitt 1922; Agamben 2003); symptomatic reading in the tradition of Althusser and Jameson (1981), attentive to what texts disclose against their manifest intentions; feminist, queer, Black feminist and decolonial critique of reproduction, kinship and the human; and film-philosophy, which treats cinematic form as a mode of thought rather than a vehicle for content (Bazin 1958–62; Cavell 1971; Deleuze 1985). Citation follows an author–date convention keyed to original publication; scripture is cited from the Authorized Version and the Coverdale Psalter; classical texts by standard numeration. Paraphrase is preferred to quotation wherever the argument does not turn on wording.

TERMINOLOGY The following terms are proposed here: *filiative contract*, *palliative sovereignty*, *natal exception*, *thalassic natality*, *arrivant identity*, *natal criterion of legitimacy*, *autoimmune nativism*, *kenotic-maieutic masculinity*, *anti-decisionist form* and *humanism of the wake*. Where a coinage adapts an existing term—Derrida's *arrivant*, Agamben's *destituent potential*, Sharpe's *wake*—the debt is marked at the point of use.

INTRODUCTION

The Interregnum of the Species

BOTH VERSIONS OF *Children of Men* begin with an obituary. James's novel opens with the death of the last human being to have been born, killed in a brawl in a suburb of Buenos Aires; Cuarón's film opens with customers in a London café watching television coverage of the death of 'Baby Diego,' the world's youngest person, also killed in Buenos Aires. The narratives begin not with a birth but with the death of the last birth—the extinction of the species' most recent beginning. Gramsci, describing the crisis of the interwar order, wrote that the old was dying while the new could not be born, and that in such an interregnum morbid symptoms of every kind proliferate. *Children of Men* removes the metaphor. Its interregnum is demographic: the old are dying, the new literally cannot be born, and the morbid symptoms—ritual euthanasia, camps and cages, state pornography, christened dolls, a museum built for no future visitor—are the institutions a society improvises when it has lost the future and must still administer the present.

The premise is philosophically peculiar. The catastrophes of twentieth-century apocalyptic fiction—nuclear war, plague, impact—are catastrophes of destruction: something is annihilated. Global infertility is a catastrophe of subtraction. Nothing is destroyed; cities stand, art survives, governments govern; what disappears is the future as such. The world ends, in Eliot's phrase, not with a bang but a whimper—and the film's most audacious gesture, this dissertation argues, is to make a whimper, an infant's cry, the sound that silences the bang. Because nothing but posterity is removed, the premise operates as what Husserl called eidetic variation: the imaginative alteration of a phenomenon in order to discover which of its features are essential. Subtract posterity from the human world and observe what survives. The diptych's answer is disquieting. Labor survives, consumption survives, administration survives, even art survives; what does not survive is politics in the strong sense—action, promise, foundation, hope—because politics turns out to have been premised all along on the arrival of the newcomer.

Two conjunctures frame the diptych. The novel appeared in 1992: the year of Francis Fukuyama's *The End of History and the Last Man* and Jean Baudrillard's

L'Illusion de la fin, of the Maastricht Treaty and the Rio Earth Summit, and of the meta-analysis in which Carlsen and colleagues reported in the *BMJ* a decline in human semen quality over half a century. James's sterile England is the end of history read through an Anglican lens: a posthistorical society of managed comfort, of the kind Kojève (1947) imagined and Fukuyama celebrated, revealed as despair. The film appeared in 2006: a year after the London bombings of July 2005, two years after the photographs from Abu Ghraib, amid the occupation of Iraq, the camp at Guantánamo, the passage of the United Kingdom's Identity Cards Act and an expanding regime of immigration detention. Cuarón reads infertility through the securitization of migration. The same year produced Jonathan Lear's *Radical Hope*, Cormac McCarthy's *The Road*, David Benatar's *Better Never to Have Been*, John D. Caputo's *The Weakness of God*, Linda Hutcheon's *A Theory of Adaptation* and James Lovelock's *The Revenge of Gaia*—a constellation in which the questions whether there ought to be a future, and what one owes it, acquired unusual density.

The diptych's reception has been lopsided. The film became a touchstone of left cultural theory: Žižek, in commentary recorded for its home-video release, argued that its true subject lies in its background, which must be viewed obliquely, as an anamorphosis; Mark Fisher opened *Capitalist Realism* (2009) with it, reading its sterility as the cultural exhaustion of a world unable to imagine an alternative to itself. Formalist criticism has concentrated on its long takes. The novel has been read chiefly as Christian allegory or as a curiosity in a crime novelist's career, and analytic philosophy has borrowed its premise as a thought experiment, most influentially in Samuel Scheffler's *Death and the Afterlife* (2013). Less often attempted is a reading of the two versions together, as a dialectical pair whose differences amount to an argument about the political form of futurity, and a reading that brings political theology into contact with Black feminist thought on reproduction, kinship and the Atlantic. This dissertation undertakes both.

Its argument can be stated in seven propositions.

1 Infertility in *Children of Men* is overdetermined—a condensation of nihilism, posthistory, capitalist realism, ecological dread and secular malaise—but its philosophical function is exact: it subtracts posterity in order to disclose posterity as a condition of the human world.

2 Posterity is the hidden premise of the political. Its collapse dissolves the *filiative contract* and produces, in both texts, a *palliative sovereignty*: a biopolitics without *bios* that administers a population able only to decline.

3 Under these conditions two theologies of the miracle compete: the sovereign exception, which Schmitt (1922) modeled on the miracle, and natality, which Arendt (1958), after Augustine, called the miracle that saves the world.

4 In both texts the future is borne by the body the regime excluded—Julian's malformed hand, Kee's foreign Blackness—so that the child is the stone the builders refused (Psalm 118:22). The texts diverge in what they make of this reversal: the novel re-filiates the future; the film de-filiates it.

5 The film's ceasefire at Bexhill is a *natal exception*: an interruption of sovereign violence that founds nothing. It is destituent rather than constituent, which is why it fails as politics and must be completed as exodus.

6 The exodus is maritime. *Thalassic natality* names the claim that the newcomer can be received only in a commons beyond the territorial *nomos*, figured as the sea—a sea that is also, as the Middle Passage and the contemporary Mediterranean insist, a grave.

7 The newborn and the refugee occupy a single political-ontological position—the *arrivant identity*—from which follow a natal criterion of political legitimacy and a *humanism of the wake*.

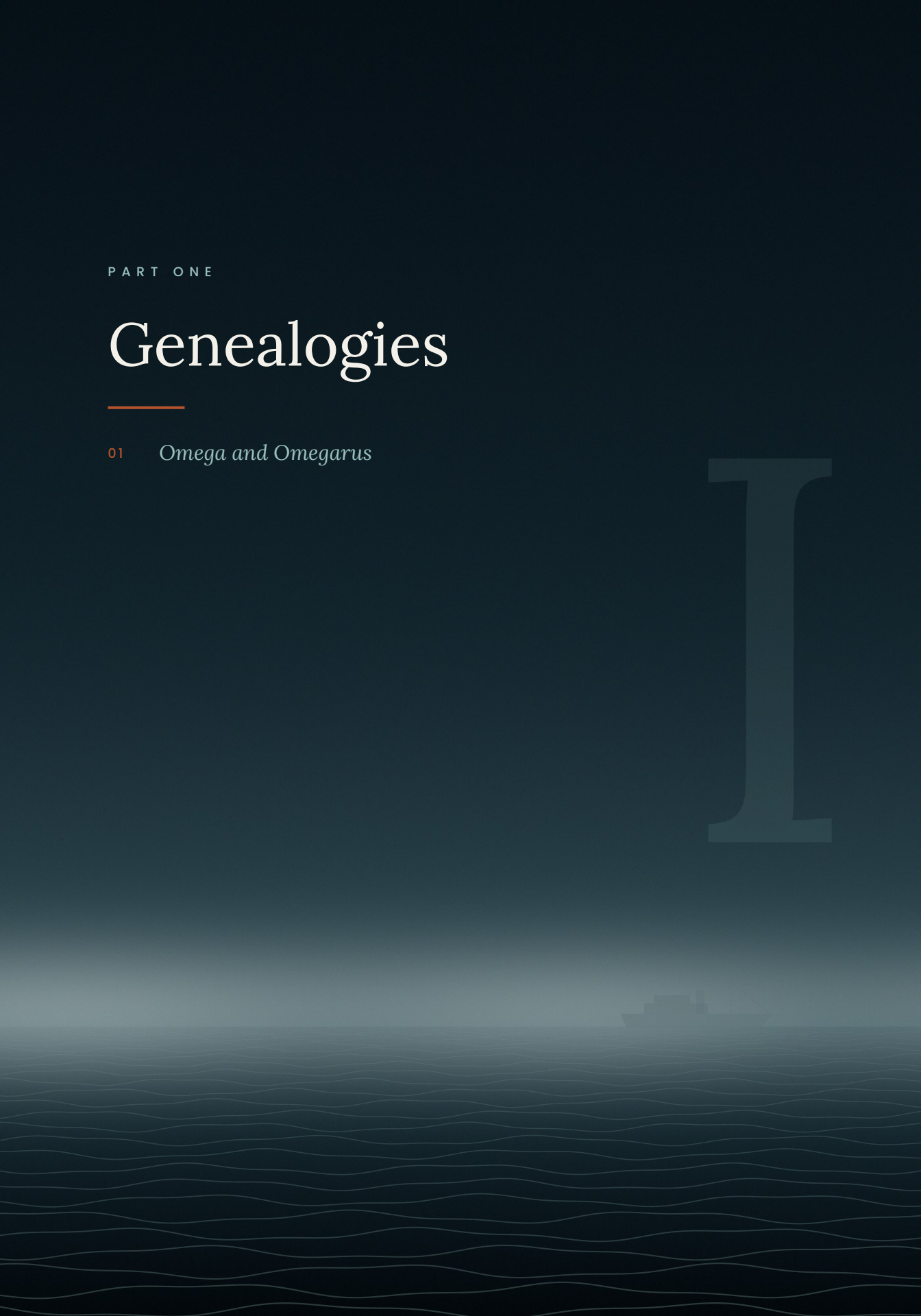
The chapters proceed in six movements. Chapter 1 reconstructs the genealogy of sterility from the barren matriarchs of Genesis through the Last Man tradition to the demographic present. Chapters 2 to 4 theorize the filiative contract and read the novel and the film as two regimes generated by its collapse. Chapters 5 and 6 develop the natal exception and thalassic natality. Chapters 7 to 9 examine gender, reproduction, race and masculinity. Chapters 10 and 11 turn to art, form, faith and hope. Chapter 12 assembles the argument into the humanism of the wake and answers the strongest objections to it.



PART ONE

Genealogies

01 *Omega and Omegarus*



CHAPTER

1

Omega and Omegarus

A *Genealogy of Sterility*

THE PREMISE OF *Children of Men* is new only in its universality. Sterility is among the oldest figures of crisis in the Western imagination, and the diptych inherits four genealogies of it: the biblical theology of the barren womb, the Romantic and post-Romantic narrative of the Last Man, the modernist myth of the Waste Land, and the demographic discourse that runs from Malthus to the population forecasts of the present. Each genealogy supplies a structure; none supplies a cause—and the refusal of cause, the chapter concludes, is the key to the premise's philosophical function.

1.1 The barren womb and the annunciation type-scene

The narratives of origin in the Hebrew Bible are punctuated by barren women: Sarah (Genesis 11:30), Rebekah (25:21), Rachel, whose cry to Jacob—'Give me children, or else I die' (30:1)—could stand as the motto of James's England, Hannah (1 Samuel 1), the unnamed mother of Samson (Judges 13) and, in the New Testament, Elizabeth (Luke 1). Robert Alter (1981) identified in these stories a recurrent type-scene, the annunciation to the barren wife, whose theological logic is constant: barrenness is the precondition of election, and the child who ends it is a gift rather than a product, an event of covenant rather than of nature. The diptych universalizes the type-scene. Humanity becomes Sarah, laughing in disbelief at the promise, and the narrative question becomes to whom the annunciation will now be made.

Scripture's answer is frequently the outsider. Matthew's genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:1–16) departs from patrilineal convention to name four women—Tamar,

Rahab, Ruth and ‘her that had been the wife of Urias’—each foreign, irregular or compromised, and Ruth the Moabite, great-grandmother of David, is the archetype of the stranger through whom the messianic line passes. Exodus opens with a still more pertinent scene: a Pharaoh alarmed that an immigrant people is multiplying, a royal order to kill its male infants, the civil disobedience of the midwives Shiphrah and Puah, and an infant set upon the water in a vessel watched over by his sister, whom tradition names Miriam (Exodus 1:8–2:10). The Hebrew word for that vessel, *tevah*, occurs elsewhere only for Noah’s ark. Here, in compressed form, is the plot of Cuarón’s film: a state’s panic about the fertility of foreigners, a midwife named Miriam, and an infant carried to safety on the water in a small boat. Matthew repeats the structure in the Massacre of the Innocents and the Flight into Egypt, in which the Holy Family are refugees from a king who fears a child, and in which the evangelist hears again Jeremiah’s Rachel weeping for her children ‘because they are not’ (Matthew 2:18). The Apocalypse supplies the last term: a woman in labor, a dragon waiting to devour her child, a flight into the wilderness, and a flood poured from the serpent’s mouth to sweep the mother away (Revelation 12).

The title belongs to the same archive. James took it from Psalm 90 in the Coverdale Psalter: ‘Thou turnest man to destruction: again thou sayest, Come again, ye children of men.’ Psalm 90 is the only psalm superscribed as ‘A Prayer of Moses the man of God’—the prayer, that is, of the infant once set adrift in the *tevah*. Its Hebrew, *shuvu venei-adam*, names humans as the offspring of *adam*, the earthling formed from *adamah*, the soil, and its verb, *shuvu*, is the root of *teshuvah*, return or repentance, which the Vulgate renders *convertimini*. The title thus holds two temporalities in a single imperative—return as conversion and return as renewed coming—and the Conclusion argues that the diptych distributes them between its protagonist and its child.

1.2 The Last Man and the sterile earth

The modern secular genealogy begins in 1805 with Jean-Baptiste Cousin de Grainville’s *Le Dernier Homme*, translated in 1806 as *The Last Man; or, Omegarus and Syderia, A Romance in Futurity*. Grainville imagines an exhausted earth and a sterile humanity; the last couple able to reproduce are Omégare and Sydérie, and Adam is sent from purgatory to persuade Omégare to renounce procreation so that history may close and the Last Judgment begin. Whether or not James knew the text, her ‘Omegas’—the final cohort, born in 1995—inherit its eschatological onomastics, and Grainville’s Adam is literature’s first antinatalist, a theological voice arguing that the kindest act toward the unborn is to leave them unborn.

Byron’s ‘Darkness’ (1816) and Thomas Campbell’s ‘The Last Man’ (1823) transposed the figure into Romantic cosmology; Mary Shelley’s *The Last Man* (1826) gave it decisive novelistic form. Shelley’s plague annihilates humanity in the late

twenty-first century, and her narrator, Lionel Verney, ends by setting out alone in a small boat on the Mediterranean, carrying books, in search of anyone left alive. The canonical English novel of extinction ends with the last man on the sea in a small boat; Cuarón's film ends with the first child on the sea in a small boat. Shelley's biography sharpens the inversion. Her mother, Mary Wollstonecraft, author of *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792), died of puerperal fever days after giving birth to her; Shelley had lost children of her own; her husband had drowned in 1822. The feminist genealogy of the Last Man is written between childbirth and drowning, between the womb and the sea.

The figure persisted. H. G. Wells's Time Traveller watches the last life on a terminal beach beneath a swollen sun (1895); M. P. Shiel's *The Purple Cloud* (1901) ends with its Adamic survivor discovering a woman and resolving to repopulate; Richard Jefferies's *After London* (1885) pastoralizes the collapse. The most direct precursor of James is Brian Aldiss's *Greybeard* (1964), in which radiation from nuclear testing has sterilized humanity and an aging population drifts through a depopulated England. Aldiss supplies a cause and therefore a culprit, Cold War techno-science; James's refusal of cause marks the distance between them. The opposite pole is Kurt Vonnegut's *Galápagos* (1985), in which a microorganism destroys human ova and the only fertile survivors, stranded on an island after a cruise, become the ancestors of a small-brained, seal-like, aquatic humanity. Vonnegut, an honorary president of the American Humanist Association, wrote a satire against the big brain as the source of human misery; his thalassic future preserves the species by shrinking it. Cuarón's thalassic future preserves the human by receiving it.

1.3 The Waste Land and the Fisher King

Modernism gave sterility its mythic grammar. Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920), drawing on Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890), read the Grail romances as survivals of fertility rites in which the land's barrenness depends upon the wound of its king, and Eliot built *The Waste Land* (1922) on that scaffolding: a sterile land, a wounded Fisher King, a fourth section entitled 'Death by Water', and a final section, 'What the Thunder Said', that closes on the Upanishadic *Shantih shantih shantih*. The film prints those words on its final screen. The militant cell at the center of both versions is named the Fishes—in James explicitly for the early Christian *ichthys*, but inevitably also for the Fisher King whose healing is the object of the quest—and Theo, in the film, dies on the water as the vessel of the future appears. Eliot's 'The Hollow Men' (1925) supplied the century's most quoted account of an ending without catastrophe: not with a bang but a whimper. The diptych's infertility is the whimper-apocalypse made literal, and the film's inversion of it—an infant's whimper that silences gunfire—is the subject of Chapter 5.

1.4 Malthus inverted

The demographic genealogy runs from Thomas Malthus's *Essay on the Principle of Population* (1798) through Paul Ehrlich's *The Population Bomb* (1968) and the Club of Rome's *The Limits to Growth* (1972). For two centuries the demographic apocalypse was one of surplus; James inverts it into an apocalypse of deficit, and thereby exposes the object Foucault placed at the center of modern power. Biopolitics takes population as its object, and population is a quantity whose management presupposes its renewal. A population that cannot renew itself is a biopolitical object without a future, and the regimes the diptych depicts are, as Chapter 2 argues, what biopolitics becomes when there is nothing left to foster.

The premise's empirical shadow has lengthened since 1992. Carlsen and colleagues' meta-analysis of that year reported a substantial decline in sperm density over fifty years; meta-regressions by Levine and colleagues (2017; 2023) reported continued declines, and Shanna Swan's *Count Down* (2021) popularized findings that remain methodologically contested. Fertility has fallen below replacement across most high-income societies; South Korea's total fertility rate reached roughly 0.7 in 2023, and the Global Burden of Disease fertility collaborators (2024) projected that a large majority of the world's countries will be below replacement by mid-century. Demography has become ideological terrain. Nativist state pronatalism—Viktor Orbán's government in Hungary, for instance, introduced in 2019 a lifetime income-tax exemption for mothers of four or more children and presented its family policy as the nation's alternative to immigration—together with natalist movements and the white-nationalist conspiracy theory of a 'Great Replacement' (Renaud Camus 2011), which claims that elites are deliberately replacing white Europeans with non-white immigrants, all read the premise of *Children of Men* in one direction. The film, Chapter 8 argues, reads it in the other: the only future available to the native polity is the stranger's child.

1.5 Overdetermination and eidetic subtraction

What does infertility mean in the diptych? The question admits too many answers. In Nietzsche's idiom it figures the Last Man, the creature who has invented happiness and blinks, the bearer of passive nihilism (*Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Prologue §5). In the Hegelian idiom revived by Kojève and Fukuyama it figures posthistory, the condition in which nothing new can occur. For Jameson (1994) and Fisher (2009) it figures capitalist realism, the incapacity to imagine any future but the extension of the present, and the slow cancellation of the future that Franco Berardi (2011) diagnosed. Ecologically it figures the Anthropocene and what Günther Anders called the time of the end—an epoch that may at any moment become the end of time. In Charles Taylor's account of secularity (2007) it figures the malaise of immanence; in Freud, melancholia; in Lacan, the foreclosure of the paternal function through which the symbolic order is transmitted.

Each reading is defensible; together they confirm that the figure is overdetermined in Freud's and Althusser's sense, a condensation of several determinations into a single image. Yet the allegorical readings share a defect: they dissolve the premise's literality into a sign for something else. The diptych resists this. Neither version explains its sterility—science fails in James, and in Cuarón the cause is never named—and the refusal of cause shifts attention from the origin of the catastrophe to its phenomenology. The premise is less a metaphor for a crisis than an eidetic subtraction that isolates a condition. What the diptych is finally about is not infertility but posterity: the invisible premise on which, the next chapter argues, every institution of the human world had been silently built.



PART TWO

The Filiative Contract and Its Regimes

II

02 *The Filiative Contract*

03 *Omega England*

04 *Homeland*

CHAPTER

2

The Filiative Contract

Posterity as the Hidden Premise of the Political

EVERY POLITICAL THEORY presupposes an answer to a question it rarely asks: whether there will be anyone after us. The social contract tradition imagines consenting adults; the theory of the state imagines a people persisting through time; economics discounts the future at a rate that presumes its existence; scholarship, art and religion address readers, viewers and believers not yet born. I call this tacit presupposition the *filiative contract*: the intergenerational covenant, seldom articulated because never in doubt, through which institutions derive legitimacy and individuals derive motive from the expectation of successors. *Children of Men* is the experiment that voids it.

2.1 Burke, Jefferson, Paine

The contract's classical statement is Edmund Burke's. In the *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790), society is a partnership 'between those who are living, those who are dead, and those who are to be born,' a clause in the great primeval contract of an eternal order. Burke's opponents denied that the dead could bind the living: Thomas Paine (1791) mocked the presumption of governing beyond the grave, and Thomas Jefferson, writing to James Madison in September 1789, held that the earth belongs in usufruct to the living. The debate assumed what neither side questioned: that there would always be a living generation to whom the earth would pass. The diptych makes Jefferson's dictum literally and monstrously true. The earth belongs to the living alone because the living are a closed, finite and aging set, and the usufruct has no remainder. James's England is a Jeffersonian dystopia administered in Burkean costume: the pageantry of continuity survives, emptied of the third term of Burke's partnership.

2.2 Kant's strange labor

Kant's 'Idea for a Universal History with a Cosmopolitan Purpose' (1784) confesses a perplexity: it seems strange that earlier generations should carry on their burdensome labors only for the sake of later ones, who alone will inhabit the building their ancestors raised. The perplexity is resolved by the thesis that the natural capacities of reason are fully developed only in the species, never in the individual, so that the meaning of each life is borrowed from a future it will not see. Remove the future and Kant's philosophy of history loses its object. The moral law, indifferent to consequences, survives; the hope that history tends toward a cosmopolitan condition does not. Kant's cosmopolitanism also supplies a term to which Chapter 12 returns: the right of hospitality, which *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) grounds in the finite, spherical surface of the earth, on which human beings cannot disperse infinitely and must therefore tolerate one another's presence.

2.3 Benjamin's secret agreement

The second of Walter Benjamin's theses 'On the Concept of History' (1940) posits a secret agreement between past generations and the present one: we were expected on earth, and each generation is endowed with a weak messianic power to which the past has a claim. The agreement runs in two directions—the living redeem the dead by remembering and completing their interrupted struggles, and await in turn their own redemption from those who come after. The last generation stands at the agreement's rupture. It can redeem no one, because the claim of the past can be honored only by a future, and no one will redeem it. The infertile world is the dead end of Benjaminian time.

2.4 Scheffler's afterlife conjecture

The most rigorous recent elaboration of the filiative contract was occasioned by James's novel itself. Samuel Scheffler's *Death and the Afterlife* (2013) uses an infertility scenario drawn from the novel to argue that the continued existence of humanity after our deaths—a collective afterlife—matters to us in some respects more than our personal survival. Were we to learn that no one would live after us, many of our projects—research whose payoff lies beyond our lifetimes, institutions built to last, scholarship, much of art—would lose their point, and much of our valuing, which Scheffler shows to be conservative in structure, would falter. The novel confirms the conjecture phenomenologically: in James's Oxford, scholarship persists as ritual without students; pleasures persist; projects whose sense depended on posterity wither. The film adds a counter-case that Scheffler's analysis predicts: the obsessive, irrational preservation of artworks for no future viewer, which Chapter 10 reads as archive fever.

2.5 Parfit, Jonas and the imperative of continuation

Derek Parfit concluded *Reasons and Persons* (1984) by comparing three outcomes: peace; a nuclear war that kills ninety-nine per cent of humanity; and one that kills everyone. Most people judge the difference between the first and second greater than that between the second and third; Parfit argued that the latter is far greater, because extinction forecloses the whole future of the species. Contemporary longtermism (Ord 2020; MacAskill 2022) is a secularized and quantified filiative contract built on that intuition. Hans Jonas's *The Imperative of Responsibility* (1979) gives it ontological form. Jonas reformulates the categorical imperative for a technological age—act so that the effects of one's action remain compatible with the permanence of genuine human life—and grounds the first of all duties, that there be a humanity at all, in the archetype of the newborn, whose mere breathing addresses an irrefutable 'ought' to the world around it. Jonas makes the infant the foundation of ethics. *Children of Men* stages the converse: an ethics without newborns, whose responsibilities, deprived of their archetype, decay into administration.

2.6 The antinatalist rejoinder

The filiative contract has always had dissenters. Schopenhauer judged existence a debt contracted at birth and repaid in suffering; David Benatar's *Better Never to Have Been* (2006) argues from an asymmetry—the absence of pain is good even when no one exists to enjoy that absence, whereas the absence of pleasure is bad only when someone is deprived of it—that coming into existence is always a harm. On this view a universal sterility that ended humanity painlessly would be a benefaction, and Grainville's Adam would be right. Both versions institutionalize something like this conclusion in the Quietus: in the novel a public ritual of drowning for the old, in the film a suicide kit advertised on television. The diptych does not refute Benatar's argument, which concerns the interests of possible persons rather than the world of actual ones. It answers a different question: what it is like to inhabit the world antinatalism recommends. The answer is not the painless good the asymmetry predicts but despair—a despair that belongs not to the unborn but to the living, whose valuing presupposed them.

2.7 The *vita activa* without natality

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) distinguishes three fundamental activities: labor, which sustains the cyclical metabolism of life; work, which fabricates a durable world of objects; and action, which initiates new beginnings among a plurality of persons. Each is conditioned by natality, in different degrees, and the infertile world dismantles them in sequence. Labor continues—it intensifies, performed by imported Sojourners in the novel and by caged 'fugees' in the film—but it has become metabolism without reproduction. Work continues, but the world it fabricates has lost its function, because for Arendt the common world is what we enter at birth and leave behind at death; a world with no one to inherit it is no longer a world but a stockpile. Action becomes impossible, because action is the actualization of the capacity to begin that each human being acquires by being born. A polity without natality can labor, produce and administer; it cannot act.

Reinhart Koselleck (1979) characterized modernity by the widening gap between the space of experience and the horizon of expectation; François Hartog (2003) diagnosed the late-modern collapse of that gap into presentism, a regime of historicity in which the present becomes omnipresent. The infertile world is presentism's reduction to absurdity: the horizon of expectation does not merely narrow, it vanishes, and the space of experience becomes the only space there is.

A polity without natality can labor, produce and administer; it cannot act.

2.8 Palliative sovereignty

What remains is a form of rule I call *palliative sovereignty*: government as hospice, administering the comfortable or uncomfortable decline of a terminal population. Its instruments are those of the hospice—sedation, distraction, euthanasia, security against intruders—and its legitimacy derives from its capacity to manage an ending rather than to secure a continuation. Foucault (1976) defined biopower as the power to make live and let die. Palliative sovereignty can no longer make live, because there is no new life to foster, and it therefore collapses toward its necropolitical remainder, the powers to let die and to make die (Mbembe 2003). James's Warden governs a palliative autocracy of consent; Cuarón's Homeland Security governs a palliative security state of fear. The next two chapters read these regimes in turn.

CHAPTER

3

Omega England

P. D. James's Anglican Dystopia

3.1 The detective of the species

P. D. JAMES (1920–2014) was the most distinguished English crime novelist of her generation, the creator of Adam Dalgliesh, a long-serving administrator in the National Health Service and in the Home Office's criminal policy department, a devout Anglican devoted to the Book of Common Prayer, and, from 1991, a Conservative life peer. *The Children of Men* is the only one of her novels set in the future, and it is best understood as a detective story whose crime has no culprit. W. H. Auden's 'The Guilty Vicarage' (1948) describes the classical detective story as a dialectic of innocence and guilt: a community in a state of grace is disturbed by a murder, suspicion falls on all, and the identification of the guilty one restores the rest to innocence. James transposes the dialectic to the species and arrests it at its second term. Humanity has suffered a catastrophe for which no one can be found guilty; science, cast as detective, fails to identify a cause; the community, unable to expel a culprit, remains suspended in a generalized guilt that no investigation can lift. The novel's moral detection therefore shifts from the cause of the catastrophe to the crimes committed in its aftermath—the Quietus, the penal island, the exploitation of the Sojourners—and its restoration of order, when it comes, comes from no investigator but from grace.

3.2 Theo's diary

The novel is divided into two books, 'Omega' and 'Alpha', inverting the self-designation of the God of the Apocalypse (Revelation 1:8), and alternates between the private diary of Theodore Faron, an Oxford historian of the Victorian period, and a third-person narration that follows him into events the diary cannot contain. The diary is the novel's formal thesis. Theo writes, like Orwell's Winston Smith, in a society that has administered away the private, but whereas Winston addresses his diary to the future or the past, Theo writes for no one—the last diarist of a species without readers. His period is pointed: the historian of the century of progress lives at the moment when progress has lost its subject. His sensibility is that of Kierkegaard's aesthete in *Either/Or* (1843): ironic, detached, cultivated, unable to commit, secretly in despair. The novel's spiritual arc moves him, in Kierkegaard's terms, from the aesthetic toward the ethical and religious stages, and the wound that motivates the movement is paternal. Years before the action, Theo killed his infant daughter, Natalie, by reversing his car over her, and his marriage did not survive it. Guilt, in James's moral psychology, is the precondition of grace; her hero is a father who had destroyed his own posterity before the species lost its own.

3.3 The Warden

England is ruled by Xan Lyppiatt, Theo's cousin and former intimate, Warden of England, governing through a small Council with the exhausted consent of the governed; Theo once served as his adviser. Xan is the most Hobbesian figure in late-twentieth-century fiction: his authority rests on an exchange of liberty for protection, and his subjects have surrendered their political freedoms not through terror but through fatigue. The bargain is a curtailed version of Roosevelt's Four Freedoms (1941): freedom from fear and want is guaranteed, while freedom of speech and of worship are less abolished than rendered irrelevant, displaced by diversion. Xan is also a Platonic guardian, ruling because he alone has the will to, and his charisma, in Weber's typology (1919), has been routinized into the procedures of a council and a bureaucracy. He is not cruel by temperament; the regime's cruelties are administrative. This is the novel's acutest political perception: in a palliative sovereignty, despotism requires no despot, only managers.

In a palliative sovereignty, despotism requires no despot, only managers.

3.4 The apparatus of decline

The regime's biopolitical apparatus bears out Foucault's critique of the repressive hypothesis (1976): power in modernity incites sexuality rather than repressing it, multiplying its discourses in order to administer populations. James's state maintains national pornography shops, compels the regular testing of men's semen, and subjects selected healthy women to periodic gynecological examination. Marcuse (1964) would have recognized the shops as repressive desublimation, the administered release of desire in the service of order. But the incitement is futile, and the population's emotional life migrates to simulacra. Women push dolls in prams and stage christenings for kittens. In Baudrillard's terms (1981) these are simulacra without originals; in Winnicott's (1953) they are transitional objects that lead nowhere, comforters that never yield to reality because there is no reality to yield to.

The last cohort, the Omegas born in 1995, are beautiful, cold, idolized and feared; some form the 'Painted Faces,' gangs whose violence has the ritual quality René Girard (1972) attributed to sacrificial crises in which differences collapse. The Quietus, a public ceremony at which the old, dressed in white and singing, are drowned at sea, is the regime's liturgy. Durkheim (1897) distinguished altruistic suicide, in which the individual is absorbed by the group, from fatalistic suicide, produced by excessive regulation; the Quietus is both at once, a sacrament of death that borrows the forms of religion—vestments, hymns, procession—for an act of state. Its medium deserves notice: in the novel the sea is a grave. The film will reverse this.

Two further institutions complete the apparatus. Offenders are deported to the Isle of Man, turned into a penal colony without governance—a Hobbesian state of nature produced on purpose by the sovereign, Agamben's ban (1995) in geographical form, and a domestic return of the penal transportation by which Britain shipped some 160,000 convicts to its Australian colonies between 1788 and 1868 (a colonization that dispossessed Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples), a boomerang of the kind Césaire (1950), Arendt (1951) and Foucault (1976) described, by which colonial techniques come home. The Sojourners—young guest workers imported from poorer countries to perform menial labor and to care for an aging population, and expelled when they reach sixty—are the novel's most prescient invention. Claude Meillassoux (1975) explained the economics of such regimes: the metropole purchases the productive years of migrant workers while externalizing the costs of their reproduction and old age to the societies from which they came. Arlie Hochschild (2000) later named the global care chain through which women from the global South care for the children and elders of the North. James's England, unable to reproduce its own labor force, consumes the labor of other people's

children while refusing them membership. Here, in a Conservative novelist's text, is the seed the film will grow into its central concern.

3.5 The Five Fishes

Against the regime stand the Five Fishes, a cell whose name and symbol recall the *ichthys* of the catacombs and whose structure is that of a primitive church. Julian, its spiritual center, is devout and has a malformed hand, which led the regime to exclude her, as unfit, from its program of fertility examination. Luke is an Anglican priest who celebrates the sacrament in improvised and abandoned places. Rolf, Julian's husband, is the cell's ambitious leader; Miriam is a midwife, named, like the guardian of the infant Moses, for the threshold of the waters; Gascoigne is the saboteur who will be taken after attacking the apparatus of the Quietus. The Fishes' demands are reformist rather than revolutionary—an end to the Quietus, to the penal island, to the exploitation of the Sojourners, to compulsory testing—and Theo, as Xan's former adviser, is enlisted to carry them to the Warden.

Julian's hand is the hinge of the novel's theology. Plato's *Republic* (460c) prescribed that the defective offspring of the guardians be hidden away; Francis Galton gave eugenics its name in 1883; Erving Goffman (1963) analyzed stigma as spoiled identity. James's regime, still practicing eugenic selection in a world where no one conceives, excludes Julian from its surveillance as unfit—and so fails to notice that she is pregnant. The eugenic state's exclusion of the 'defective' blinds it to the only future it has. The child is the stone the builders refused (Psalm 118:22), and the logic of the refused stone, which Chapter 4 calls autoimmunity, is common to both versions of the story. The father is not Rolf but Luke, the priest. Rolf, learning this, defects to the Warden, betraying the cell in a bid to make the child the instrument of his own power: the iron law of oligarchy (Michels 1911) in miniature, the revolutionary who desires only to become sovereign.

3.6 The ending as re-filiation

The novel's climax takes place in a woodland outbuilding where Julian gives birth to a son. Xan arrives; Theo kills him; and Theo slips onto his own finger the Coronation Ring Xan wore as the emblem of rule. The novel closes with Theo's makeshift baptism of the child.

The scene condenses three structures. The first is Frazer's. *The Golden Bough* opens in the sacred grove of Diana at Nemi, where a priest-king, the *rex Nemorensis*, held office until slain by his successor, who then reigned in his place; and Diana of Nemi was a goddess to whom women prayed for offspring and safe delivery. James's ending reenacts the Nemi succession in a grove of birth: the old king is slain, and the slayer assumes the regalia. The second structure is Freud's. In *Totem and Taboo*

(1913) the primal father is killed by the band of brothers, who then reinstitute his law in his name; the ring is the totem, and Theo, Xan's cousin and quasi-brother, becomes heir to the authority he has destroyed. In Lacanian terms, the Name-of-the-Father, whose transmission infertility had suspended, is restored. The third structure is sacramental. Baptism inscribes the child in the Church: the boy is claimed, named and incorporated.

Together these structures accomplish a *re-filiation*. The filiative contract, voided by the catastrophe, is reinstated through grace and sovereignty at once: the future is born, male and English, into a line of Church and Crown, and the man who protects it assumes the insignia of rule. The novel knows the danger of its ending. The ring is a temptation, and the text allows the reader to fear that Theo may become what he killed; Acton's maxim about power hangs over the final pages. But the novel ends inside the structure it suspects. James's conservatism is not reactionary but sacramental: the future is a gift rather than a product, unearned by science or state—yet it can be received only within the forms of Church and Crown. That is the novel's theological-political wager, and it is the wager the film declines.



CHAPTER

4

Homeland

The Political Ontology of Cuarón's Britain

4.1 Adaptation as transvaluation

THE FILM RETAINS the novel's premise, its protagonist's name, several characters' names, the Fishes and the Quietus, and alters nearly everything else. The relation is best described with Nietzsche's *Umwertung*, transvaluation: the same signs, revalued. Table 1 sets out the principal transformations.

The transvaluation is systematic. Personal sovereignty becomes impersonal apparatus; the managed, internal exclusions of the novel become the militarized, visible exclusions of the film; the English, Christian, disabled mother becomes a Black African refugee; the priestly father becomes an unknown one; the son becomes a daughter; and the hero who kills the sovereign and wears his ring becomes a man who dies on the water having founded nothing. Every element that, in the novel, reinscribes the child within lineage, nation and sovereignty is removed or reversed.

TABLE 1

The diptych at a glance

DIMENSION	NOVEL (1992)	FILM (2006)
Setting	Oxford and rural England, 2021	London, the Home Counties and Bexhill, 2027
Onset of infertility	1995, the 'Omega' year	Last birth some eighteen years before the action
Opening event	Last-born human killed in a Buenos Aires brawl	'Baby Diego', the youngest person alive, killed in Buenos Aires
Sovereignty	Personal: Xan Lyppiatt, Warden of England, and his Council	Impersonal: Homeland Security and propaganda; no visible ruler
Exemplary exclusions	Sojourners, the Isle of Man penal colony, the Quietus	'Fugees', cages, the Bexhill camp, Quietus kits
Protagonist's wound	Theo killed his infant daughter Natalie in an accident	Theo's son Dylan died in an influenza pandemic
Bearer of the child	Julian: English, devout, malformed hand	Kee: a West African refugee
Father	Luke, an Anglican priest	Unknown
Child	A boy, baptized by Theo	A girl, named Dylan by her mother
Theo's fate	Kills Xan and takes the Coronation Ring	Dies in a rowing boat as the ship *Tomorrow* appears
Final horizon	Sacramental and sovereign continuity within England	Departure by sea toward the Human Project

4.2 The faceless sovereign

The film has no Warden. Its sovereignty is dispersed into an apparatus—Agamben's *dispositivo* (2006), Foucault's governmentality—visible only in its effects: billboards urging citizens to report illegal immigrants, broadcasts proclaiming that the world has collapsed while Britain alone soldiers on, notices warning that evading fertility tests is a crime, armored buses, riot police, a television advertisement for Quietus. The slogan of solitary endurance recycles the national myth of 1940, the island alone against the continent, and Chapter 8 reads it, with Paul Gilroy, as the symptom of postcolonial melancholia. The decisive formal fact is absence: the sovereign is never seen. The film thereby completes what the novel's analysis of administrative despotism implied. A palliative sovereignty needs no face, only procedures, and the procedures function with or without a ruler.

4.3 Bexhill and the camp as *nomos*

The film's political geography culminates at Bexhill-on-Sea, a seaside resort in East Sussex converted into a walled internment zone. Agamben (1995) argued that the camp, not the city, is the biopolitical paradigm of the West: the space that opens when the state of exception becomes the rule, a zone of indistinction between law and fact, inside and outside, in which human beings are reduced to bare life. His paradigm is the Nazi camp, in which the Nazi state stripped Jews, Roma and others of citizenship and legal standing before murdering millions of them, and he traces the camp's genealogy to Spanish Cuba in 1896 and to the camps into which British forces herded Boer civilians during the South African War—camps in which, historians have since documented, tens of thousands of Boer and Black African civilians died. To call Bexhill a camp in his sense is not to equate it with Auschwitz; it is to identify in it the juridical operation that made the camps possible, the placing of a population outside the protection of law. Bexhill is that zone rendered as cinema, and the zone has a British genealogy. Its entrance is a gauntlet of cages in which Homeland Security troops sort, beat and hood detainees, among them a hooded figure who reproduces the most notorious photograph from Abu Ghraib, the prison near Baghdad where in 2003 United States military personnel abused and humiliated Iraqi detainees and photographed a hooded prisoner standing on a box with wires attached to his hands, told he would be electrocuted if he fell; inside, its streets recall the urban wars of Sarajevo, Gaza and Fallujah—protest marches under Islamic banners, 'Intifada' on the walls, a mother cradling the body of her son in the attitude of a Pietà. Achille Mbembe (2003) called such spaces death-worlds, forms of social existence in which populations are conferred the status of the living dead; Zygmunt Bauman (2004) described refugees as modernity's human waste, the surplus that the order of nation-states produces and cannot recycle. Bexhill is a landfill for wasted lives.

4.4 Immunity and autoimmunity

Roberto Esposito (2002; 2004) reads modern politics through the paradigm of immunity: communities protect themselves by internalizing a controlled dose of the negative, and the protection, intensified, turns against the life it was meant to preserve. Derrida (1996; 2003) named the extreme case autoimmunity, the process by which a living being destroys its own protections. The film's Britain is autoimmune in the strict sense. Its immune response—the detection, capture and expulsion of foreign bodies—is directed against the only body on earth capable of bearing its future. Had the state found Kee before the Fishes did, it would have caged her; had it learned of her pregnancy, the film suggests, it would have seized the child and presented it to the world as British, under another mother. The novel's eugenic exclusion of Julian follows the same logic: the regime's selection of the fit blinds it to the future borne by the unfit. I call this pattern *autoimmune nativism*: the self-destruction of a polity that, in defending its identity against the stranger, destroys its own posterity. It is the pathology the diptych diagnoses, and Chapter 8 traces its contemporary forms.

4.5 Biopolitics without *bios*

Foucault's formula—to make live and let die—describes a biopolitics whose positive function is the fostering of life: hygiene, medicine, natality policy, the optimization of populations. The infertile state has lost that function. It cannot make live, because no new life arrives; it can only let die (the Quietus) and make die (the camps). The film thus demonstrates a thesis implicit in Foucault and explicit in Mbembe: biopolitics is parasitic on natality. When the population cannot renew itself, biopower's productive face disappears and its necropolitical remainder is all that is left. The novel's porn shops and testing regime are the last gestures of a biopolitics still hoping to foster; the film's cages are what that biopolitics becomes once the hope is gone.

4.6 The Fishes and the ethics of insurgency

The film's Fishes are not a primitive church but an armed movement for the rights of refugees. Their leader, Julian Taylor, Theo's former partner and the mother of his dead son, enlists him to obtain transit papers for Kee; she intends to deliver Kee to the Human Project, a scientific body rumored to be working in the Azores. Julian is killed in an ambush on a country road, and Theo later learns that her own comrades arranged her death: Luke, now the movement's leader, intends to keep the child as the banner of an uprising. The insurgency thus reproduces the state's relation to the child. Both seek to appropriate it—as a national asset or as a revolutionary emblem—and both treat Kee as the container of a resource.

The film's critique of revolutionary instrumentalism draws on a long tradition. Fanon (1961) theorized anticolonial violence as necessary and warned, in 'The Pitfalls of National Consciousness,' against elites who seize the revolution for themselves. Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) distinguished power, which arises when people act in concert, from violence, which is instrumental and can destroy power but never create it; the Fishes possess violence and no power. Horkheimer and Adorno (1944) showed how instrumental reason turns against the emancipatory ends it was meant to serve. The closest literary precedent is Albert Camus's *Les Justes* (1949), in which the revolutionary Kaliayev refuses to throw his bomb at the Grand Duke's carriage because two children are riding in it, while his comrade Stepan insists that the revolution justifies their deaths. Luke is Stepan; the film's soldiers, at the moment of the ceasefire, are Kaliayev. The film's ethical axis runs not between state and revolution but between appropriation and reception, and on that axis the state and the insurgency stand together.

4.7 Near-future realism

The film builds its future almost entirely from images of its present: Abu Ghraib, pyres of slaughtered livestock recalling Britain's foot-and-mouth epidemic of 2001, CCTV, bombings, detention centers, televised atrocity. Its future is the present's unconscious made visible. Fisher's reading captures this: the catastrophe in *Children of Men* is neither imminent nor past but lived through, a condition rather than an event. Žižek's insistence that the film's true subject lies in its background, visible only to an oblique gaze, describes a formal strategy as well as a political one. The foreground follows Theo's quest; the background, held in long takes that refuse to isolate the protagonist from his world, shows the camp, the cage, the burning cattle and the propaganda as the medium in which every foreground action occurs. Jameson's political unconscious (1981) is here not buried in the text but painted on its walls.

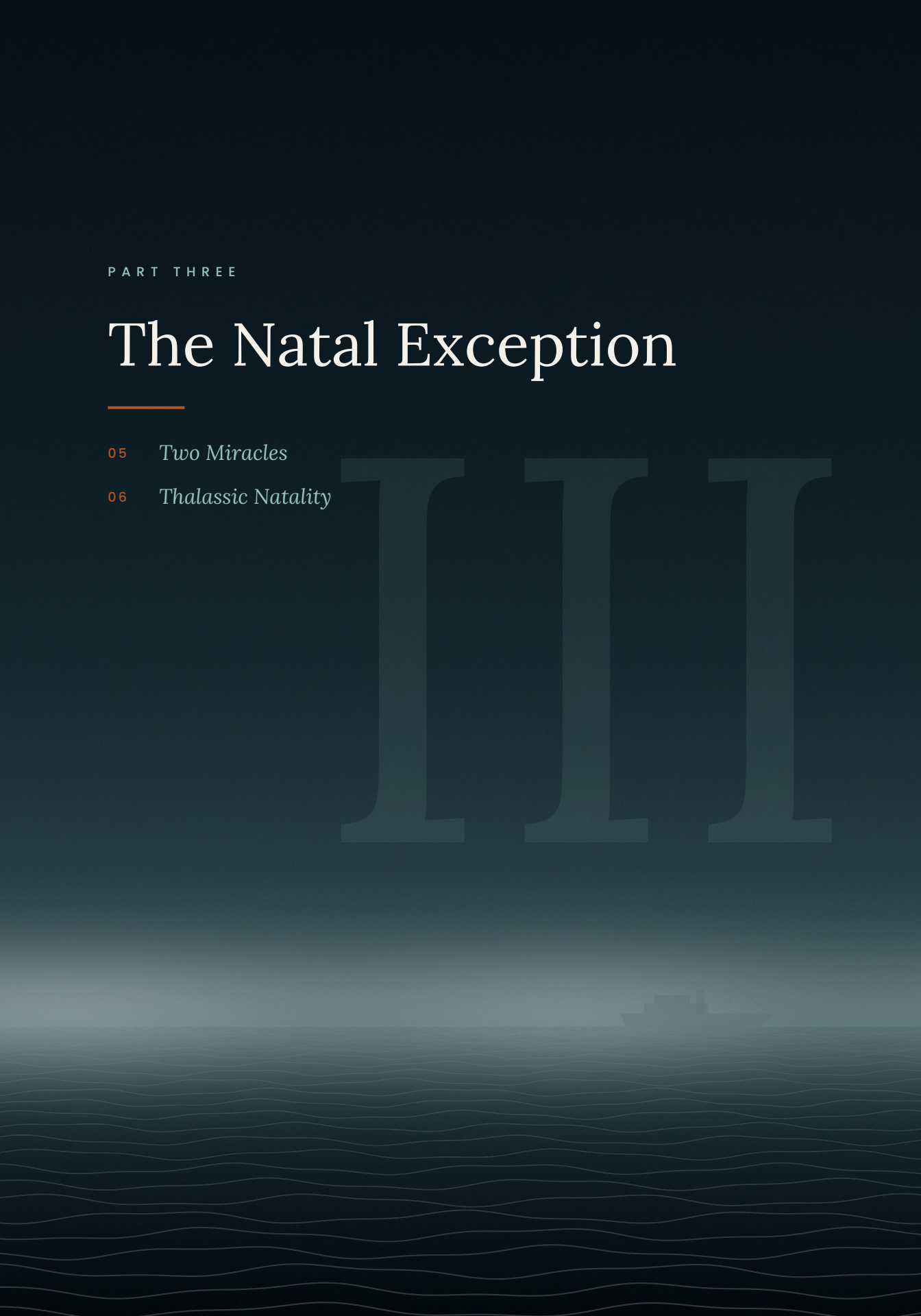
PART THREE

The Natal Exception

05 *Two Miracles*

06 *Thalassic Natality*

III



CHAPTER

5

Two Miracles

The Sovereign Exception and the Natal Exception

5.1 Schmitt's miracle

CARL SCHMITT OPENED *Political Theology* (1922) with the definition that has organized a century of debate: sovereign is he who decides on the exception. The definition rests on an analogy Schmitt made explicit. All significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts, and the exception plays in jurisprudence the role the miracle plays in theology: it is the moment at which the sovereign, like the God of the voluntarist tradition, suspends the ordinary order in order to preserve it. *The Concept of the Political* (1932) added the criterion of the political itself, the distinction between friend and enemy. The sovereign decides who is the enemy and when the norm is suspended. Benjamin's eighth thesis (1940) answered that, for the oppressed, the state of emergency is not the exception but the rule, and Agamben (2003) has argued that the exception has become the normal paradigm of government. The film's Britain is the exception made permanent: an emergency without end, whose enemy is the foreigner and whose sovereign has dissolved into the apparatus that decides.

5.2 Arendt's miracle

Against Schmitt's miracle stands another. In *The City of God* (XII.21) Augustine wrote *initium ut esset, creatus est homo*: that there might be a beginning, man was created. Hannah Arendt, whose doctoral dissertation (1929) concerned the concept of love in Augustine, made the sentence the axis of her political thought. Each human being, by being born, is a new beginning, and the capacity to act—to initiate something unforeseeable among others—is the political actualization of the fact of natality. At the close of the section of *The Human Condition* devoted to promising, Arendt calls natality the miracle that saves the world, the realm of human affairs, from its normal, natural ruin, and finds its most succinct expression in the glad tidings of the Gospels, the Isaian announcement that unto us a child is born (Isaiah 9:6), which Handel set in *Messiah*. Arendt's miracle differs from Schmitt's in every essential respect. It is not decided but undergone; it belongs not to a sovereign but to plurality; it does not suspend the order in order to preserve it but interrupts the order in order to begin; it is unpredictable by definition and cannot be monopolized.

Children of Men stages the confrontation of these two miracles. Its world is governed by Schmitt's, the permanent exception; its plot is the arrival of Arendt's. The confrontation reaches its crisis in a single sequence.

5.3 The ceasefire at Bexhill

Late in the film, after Kee has given birth in Bexhill, the camp erupts into armed uprising and the army moves in. Kee and the infant have been seized by the Fishes and are held in a tenement under bombardment. Theo enters the building in a long take that follows him through stairwells and corridors filled with smoke, rubble and the dead, finds Kee, and leads her and the child down the stairs and into the street. What happens next is the film's central event. The infant's cry is heard before she is seen. Firing in the building falters. Insurgents and civilians fall silent and draw back; hands reach out to touch the child; outside, soldiers lower their weapons, an order to cease fire is shouted, men kneel and cross themselves, and the procession—mother, child and the bloodied man who guides them—passes between the lines. Then an explosion breaks the stillness, and the battle resumes.

The sequence condenses several traditions of thought about the unarmed face.

LEVINAS For Levinas (1961) the face of the other signifies, before any content, the prohibition of murder; its nakedness is its command. The infant's face is the limit case of that nakedness, the absolutely defenseless face, and the soldiers' response is the Levinasian moment made collective: violence halts before what offers it no resistance.

CAVARERO Adriana Cavarero's *Horrorism* (2007) distinguishes the violence of terror, which threatens the living with death, from horror, violence that falls upon the

helpless and offends the human as such; the infant is the paradigm of the helpless. Her *Inclinations* (2013) contrasts the upright, autonomous subject of modern philosophy with the posture of a mother bent over a child, a subject constituted by exposure to another. The ceasefire is a collective inclination: armed, vertical men bend, kneel, lower their gaze and their guns.

CAMUS The soldiers repeat Kaliayev's refusal in *Les Justes*: the presence of a child suspends a violence that had justified itself by its end.

ELIOT A world ending in a whimper is redeemed, for a moment, by a whimper that silences the bangs. The sound that in Eliot signifies the end of the world here signifies its beginning.

BENJAMIN 'Critique of Violence' (1921) distinguishes mythic violence, which founds and preserves law, from divine violence, which destroys law and is, in Benjamin's paradoxical formulation, lethal without spilling blood. The ceasefire is stranger still: a law-suspending event that is not violent at all. It might be called divine non-violence—an interruption of mythic violence by the defenseless rather than the omnipotent.

The sound that in Eliot signifies the end of the world here signifies its beginning.

5.4 The natal exception defined

I define the *natal exception* as an event in which the appearance of a newcomer suspends the operative distinction of sovereign violence—friend and enemy, citizen and alien, life to be protected and life that may be killed—without instituting a new order of distinction. Five properties follow.

1. It is *undecidable*. No one decides it; it happens to those who undergo it. It is the exact inverse of Schmitt's sovereign decision.
2. It is *universal in address*. The infant's cry addresses soldiers and insurgents, citizens and fugees, believers and unbelievers alike, enacting the universalism Badiou (1997) finds in Paul's declaration that there is neither Jew nor Greek, bond nor free (Galatians 3:28).
3. It is *destituent*, not constituent. Agamben's late work (2014) distinguishes constituent power, which founds new orders and so reproduces sovereignty, from destituent potential, which deposes without founding. The ceasefire founds no regime, appoints no leader, issues no law.

4 It is *ephemeral*. It cannot be institutionalized, codified or prolonged by decree; it lasts as long as the passage of the child.

5 It is *relayed*. Its effects can be extended only by those who carry the newcomer onward. Fidelity to it, in Badiou's sense of fidelity to an event (1988; 1993), takes the form of conveyance.

5.5 Why the natal exception fails

The ceasefire ends. An explosion, the resumption of fire, the return of the camp: the film refuses the consolation of a miracle that lasts. The refusal is not cynicism but political realism, and Arendt supplies its terms. *On Revolution* (1963) is a meditation on the problem of foundation: the revolutionary beginning must be stabilized by institutions—constitutions, councils, promises—or it will be devoured by violence or by the restoration of sovereignty. Arendt's 'lost treasure' of the revolutionary tradition is the council, the spontaneous organ of action that revolutions produce and revolutionary states destroy. The natal exception is subject to the same paradox in its purest form. Natality needs institutions to receive it, but the institutions to hand are those of the sovereign order it suspends. A polity founded on the ceasefire would have to be a sovereignty, and a sovereignty would reinstate the distinctions the ceasefire suspended. The natal exception therefore cannot be constituted. It can only be continued, and its continuation must take the form of departure.

5.6 From exception to exodus

Michael Walzer's *Exodus and Revolution* (1985) read the Exodus narrative as the paradigm of Western revolutionary politics: liberation from bondage, a march through the wilderness, a covenant, arrival in a promised land. Walzer's Exodus is territorial; it ends in a conquest. Paolo Virno (1996; 2004) proposed a different concept of exodus: not the seizure of the state but an engaged withdrawal from it, a defection that founds alternative forms of common life without taking power; Hardt and Negri (2000; 2004) generalized the idea. The film's exodus belongs to Virno's type but exceeds it in one decisive respect: it leads not to an alternative territory but to no territory at all. Marichka guides Theo, Kee and the child through tunnels to the shore, where a rowing boat waits, and Theo, mortally wounded, rows them into the fog toward a buoy at which the *Tomorrow* is expected. The natal exception, which cannot be founded on land, is carried onto the water. Why the water, and what it means for the newcomer to be received there, is the subject of the next chapter.



CHAPTER

6

Thalassic Natality

Land, Sea, and the Ship of the Newcomer

THE FILM'S FINAL sequence takes place entirely on water: a rowing boat in fog, a dying man at the oars, a mother and child, a buoy, and the slow emergence of a ship called *Tomorrow*. This chapter argues that the location is not scenic but conceptual. The natal exception cannot be housed on land because land is the element of sovereignty; it must be received at sea, in a commons the territorial order has never fully appropriated. I call this structure *thalassic natality*.

6.1 The *nomos* of the earth

Schmitt is again the indispensable antagonist. *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950) derives all law from an original act of land-appropriation: the Greek *nomos*, from *nemein*, to divide, to pasture, to take, names the founding partition of the ground from which every legal order proceeds. The sea, Schmitt argued, knows no such unity of space and law; it cannot be fenced, cultivated or inscribed, and the European order of the modern age rested on the distinction between an appropriated land and a free sea. *Land and Sea* (1942), composed as a story told to his daughter, narrates world history as a struggle between terrestrial and maritime powers, figured through the old mythic combat of Behemoth, the beast of the land, and Leviathan, the monster of the sea. England, in this narrative, made an elemental decision for the sea and transformed itself from a terrestrial into a maritime existence, the Leviathan of the modern world.

The film's Britain has reversed that decision. The maritime power has become a land fortress, its coast a border, its seaside resorts internment camps; Leviathan has

turned Behemoth. Read against Schmitt, the ending's logic becomes legible. The sovereign exception is terrestrial: it is the decision of a power that has partitioned the land. The natal exception, which suspends that decision, finds its continuation in the element the partition never mastered. Schmitt's geography is turned against his decisionism.

6.2 *Mare liberum*, *mare clausum*

Whether the sea can be owned is the founding controversy of modern international law. Hugo Grotius's *Mare Liberum* (1609) argued that the sea, inexhaustible and incapable of occupation, is by nature common to all; John Selden's *Mare Clausum*, published in 1635 at the instance of Charles I, defended English dominion over the seas around Britain. The film's ending is Grotian: its sea is a commons in which a stateless mother and child can float beyond the reach of the land's law.

Read from the 2020s, the film's small boat carries a charge its makers could not have foreseen. British border politics has since organized itself around the figure of the 'small boat' crossing the English Channel: a governmental pledge in 2023 to 'stop the boats,' the Illegal Migration Act of the same year, a scheme to remove asylum seekers to Rwanda abandoned in 2024, and the housing of asylum seekers on the barge *Bibby Stockholm* at Portland between 2023 and 2025. This is a neo-Seldenian *mare clausum*, an attempt to extend the land's sovereignty over the sea. The Mediterranean, meanwhile, has become the deadliest migration route in the world. The drowning of more than three hundred people off Lampedusa in October 2013 and the photograph of the body of three-year-old Alan Kurdi on a Turkish beach in September 2015 fixed its image; the research group Forensic Oceanography reconstructed the fate of a migrant boat left to drift for two weeks in 2011, during NATO's military operation off Libya: its distress was reported, military aircraft and warships were in the area, no state rescued it, and sixty-three of its seventy-two passengers died (Heller and Pezzani 2012). The sea of the present is a necropolitical sea, and thalassic natality cannot be a romance of the waves. It must be dialectical: the sea is at once the commons in which the newcomer can be received and the grave in which the newcomer drowns, and which it becomes is a political decision about the land's reach. The film's achievement is to assign to the small boat the meaning that contemporary border discourse denies it—not a threat to the polity but the vessel of its future.

6.3 The heterotopia par excellence

Foucault's lecture 'Of Other Spaces' (1967) defined heterotopias as real places that function as counter-sites, in which the other sites of a culture are represented, contested and inverted. Its final paragraph names the ship the heterotopia par excellence, a floating piece of space, a place without a place, and observes that in civilizations without boats dreams dry up, espionage takes the place of adventure, and the police take the place of pirates. The sentence describes Cuarón's Britain with uncanny precision. It is a civilization without boats: its coasts are walls, its dreams have dried into the Ark of the Arts, its adventure has become surveillance, its pirates have become police. The ending restores the boat, and with it the heterotopic possibility of a space that belongs to no place.

Two further images of the ship sharpen the point. Plato's allegory of the ship of state (*Republic* 488a–489a) imagines a vessel whose true navigator is displaced by mutinous sailors; the polity is a ship that needs a pilot who knows the stars. The *Tomorrow* inverts the allegory: it is a ship without a state, and its precious passenger is not a pilot but a newcomer. Otto Neurath's image of thinkers as sailors who must rebuild their ship on the open sea, never able to bring it into dry dock and reconstruct it from the best materials, supplies the inversion's epistemology. Thalassic natality is Neurathian politics: the human must be rebuilt at sea, without foundations, from the materials at hand.

6.4 The Black Atlantic and the wake

Paul Gilroy's *The Black Atlantic* (1993) proposed the ship as the chronotope—Bakhtin's term for a fused unit of time and space—of modern Black culture: a living micro-cultural, micro-political system in motion, linking Africa, Europe and the Americas through the Middle Passage and its afterlives. The film's ending places a West African mother and her child on the Atlantic, bound for the Azores, the archipelago through which the early Portuguese Atlantic passed in the century when Portugal inaugurated the European trade in African captives. The boat performs a counter-passage. The Middle Passage, run by European and American slave traders, forced some twelve and a half million Africans onto ships as cargo to be made into property, and in the eighteenth century British ships carried more of them than any other nation's; the film's boat leaves Britain carrying an African woman's child across the same ocean as the hope of the species.

Christina Sharpe's *In the Wake* (2016) gives this reading its necessary gravity. Sharpe's *wake* has three senses: the track a ship leaves in the water; the vigil kept over the dead; and wakefulness, consciousness. Wake work is the practice of inhabiting the afterlife of slavery in all three senses at once. Sharpe reads the hold of the slave ship and the womb of the enslaved mother as conjoined sites, bound together by the colonial doctrine of *partus sequitur ventrem*, under which the child

followed the condition of the mother into slavery. The film's final sequence holds all three senses of the wake. Theo dies in the boat and Kee keeps vigil; the *Tomorrow* will leave its wake as it carries mother and child away; and the last image, fog resolving into a ship, figures a waking from the long sleep of the infertile world. The boat is a hold become a cradle.

The boat is a hold become a cradle.

6.5 Thalassa

Sándor Ferenczi's *Thalassa* (1924) proposed that sexuality and birth recapitulate the phylogenetic catastrophe in which life left the sea, and that amniotic fluid is an introjected ocean carried within the mother's body. Freud, in *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930), examined the 'oceanic feeling' Romain Rolland had described, a sensation of limitless union, and traced it to the infant's undifferentiated relation to the world. J. G. Ballard's *The Drowned World* (1962) made thalassic regression an apocalypse: as the oceans rise, consciousness descends toward its oldest strata, and the protagonist drifts south toward dissolution. Cuarón inverts Ballard's direction. His sea is not regression toward death but progression toward birth—the amniotic externalized as a commons. The film's births are wet, its final passage takes place in fog that is itself a cloud of water, and the last crossing occurs in the element every human being first inhabits.

Authorial continuity strengthens the point. Cuarón's cinema returns repeatedly to water and the maternal. *Y Tu Mamá También* (2001) ends its journey at a beach where its central woman, secretly dying, chooses to remain. *Gravity* (2013) shows its astronaut curled in a fetal posture inside a spacecraft and ends with her struggling out of a lake onto land, like the first creature to leave the water. *Roma* (2018) culminates on a beach where an Indigenous domestic worker who has delivered a stillborn daughter wades into the surf to save her employer's children and then confesses that she had not wanted her baby to be born. Across these films the sea is where maternity, death and rescue meet, and the women who bear that meeting are, with growing insistence, those whom the social order relegates to service.

6.6 Dylan, son of the wave; the two arks

Kee names her daughter Dylan, after Theo's dead son. The name has a Welsh mythological genealogy that the film does not cite but its ending activates. In the Fourth Branch of the *Mabinogi*, the child Dylan, born to Arianrhod, is baptized and immediately makes for the sea, taking on its nature and swimming like a fish; hence his epithet *Eil Ton*, son of the wave. The film's newborn is named at sea, in a story whose militants are called the Fishes, and is borne toward a ship on the waves. The name ties the dead boy of the land to the living girl of the sea and converts a father's grief into a mother's hope.

The film's architecture contains two arks. The first is the Ark of the Arts, the collection of rescued masterpieces housed in Battersea Power Station on the Thames, which Chapter 10 reads as an archive without posterity: a land-ark preserving dead works for no future viewer. The second is the rowing boat and the ship toward which it rows, the *tevah* of the infant on the water. Genesis and Exodus use the same Hebrew word for Noah's ark and for Moses's basket, and Psalm 90, from which the novel takes its title, is the prayer of the child once saved in the second of them. The film opposes an ark of artifacts to an ark of the living, and chooses the latter.

6.7 Arendt's ocean

Arendt's account of promising, in the section of *The Human Condition* that names natality the miracle that saves the world, uses a maritime figure: the future is by definition an ocean of uncertainty, within which promises establish islands of security without which neither continuity nor durability would be possible among human beings. The film literalizes the figure. The ocean of uncertainty is the fog; the island of security is the buoy at which the ship has promised to come; the promise is Julian's, inherited by Theo and kept at the cost of his life. The *Tomorrow* is the promise fulfilled, and its name inscribes on a hull the horizon of expectation that the infertile world had lost. The scene also inverts the Apocalypse. In Revelation 12 the serpent pours a flood after the fleeing mother, and the earth opens its mouth to swallow the flood and save her. In *Children of Men* the land pursues the mother and the water saves her.

6.8 Thalassic natality defined

Thalassic natality designates a mode of futurity with six features. (1) It is ex-territorial: the newcomer is received beyond the land's *nomos*. (2) It is non-appropriative: the newcomer belongs to no sovereign, movement or lineage. (3) It privileges passage over destination: the Human Project is never seen, and the film ends before arrival, on Neurath's open sea. (4) It is dialectical: the sea is womb and grave, Middle Passage and counter-passage, and the commons must be made a place of reception against the land's tendency to make it a place of death. (5) It is maternal without being patrilineal: custody passes to the mother, and the name she gives records a chosen rather than a biological kinship. (6) It figures the future not as a territory to be possessed but as a vessel to be boarded.

Matthew Arnold's 'Dover Beach' (1867) heard the Sea of Faith withdrawing from the English shore and saw a darkling plain 'where ignorant armies clash by night.' The film reverses the tide. At Bexhill the ignorant armies clash; out on the water faith returns—not as doctrine but as the willingness to row into fog toward a promise one cannot verify.



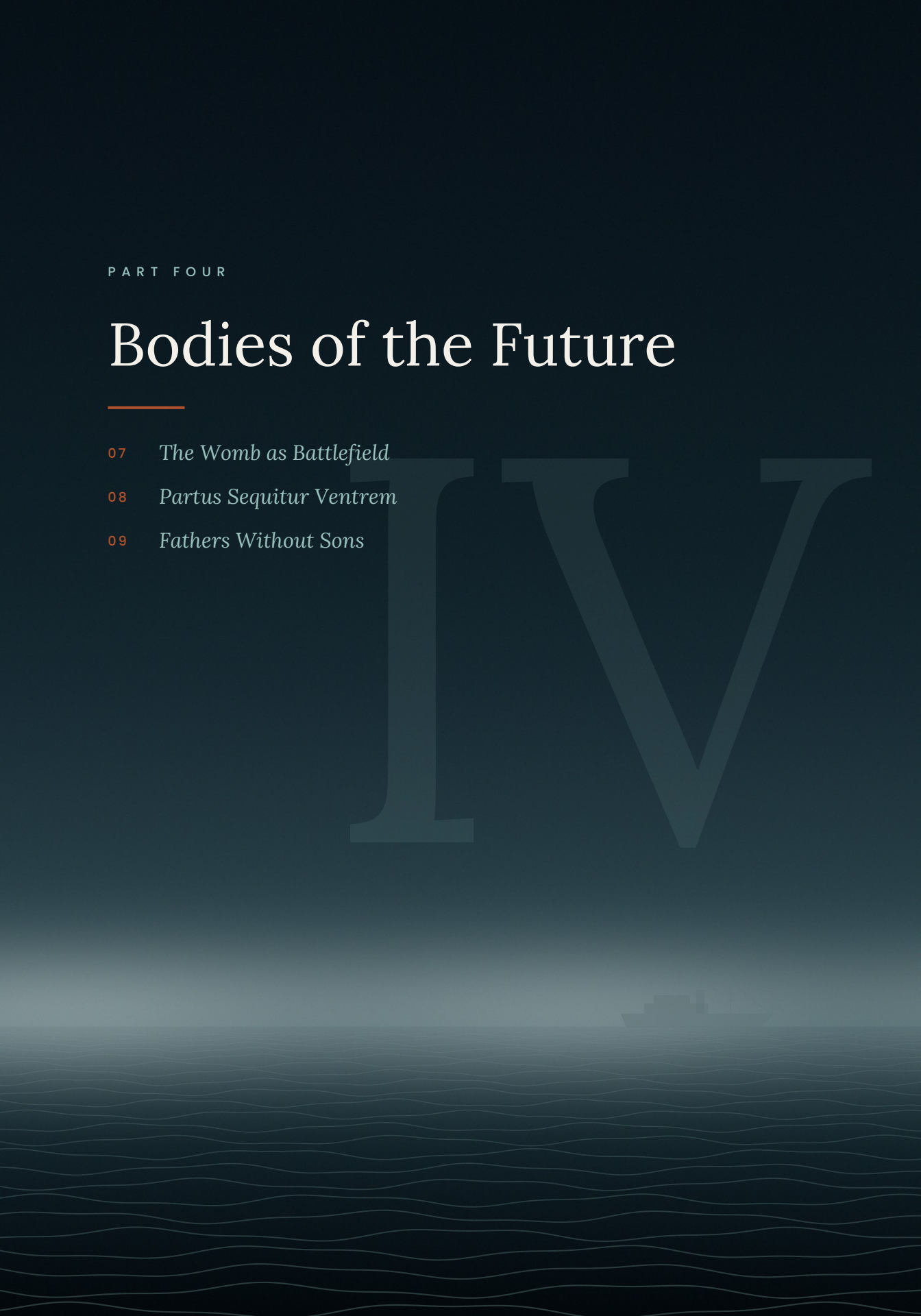
PART FOUR

Bodies of the Future

07 *The Womb as Battlefield*

08 *Partus Sequitur Ventrem*

09 *Fathers Without Sons*



CHAPTER

7

The Womb as Battlefield

Feminist Theory and the Infertile Polity

Children of Men is a story about the female body written, in its first version, by a woman and, in its second, by a group of men. Its premise abolishes the reproductive function around which much of the history of women's subordination has been organized, and its plots turn on the single body in which that function returns. Feminist theory is therefore not one lens among others but the discourse best equipped to ask what the diptych does with the womb it makes so precious.

7.1 Beauvoir: subordination without reproduction

Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (1949) argued that woman has been constituted as man's Other, confined to immanence while man claims transcendence, and that institutionalized maternity is among the principal instruments of that confinement. One might expect a world without reproduction to release women from immanence. The diptych shows the opposite. In James's England women are subjected to compulsory gynecological surveillance and channel their frustrated maternity into dolls; in Cuarón's Britain the most prominent woman leader, Julian, is murdered early, and the most precious woman is hunted. Infertility abolishes reproduction without abolishing patriarchy. The diptych thereby vindicates Beauvoir's anti-biologism: women's subordination is not a function of reproductive biology but of a symbolic order that persists when the biology fails. One is not born a woman; in the infertile world, it turns out, one is still made one.

7.2 Firestone's cybernetic dream and its negative

Shulamith Firestone's *The Dialectic of Sex* (1970) located the root of women's oppression in the biological family and called for women's liberation from reproduction by technological means, artificial gestation included. Marge Piercy's *Woman on the Edge of Time* (1976) imagined the utopia that would follow: the community of Mattapoisett, where children are gestated in 'brooders,' raised by three co-mothers of any sex, and nursed by men as well as women. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) had already imagined the dystopian version, the hatcheries of a caste society. *Children of Men* is Firestone's negative image. Reproduction has been severed from women not by liberation but by catastrophe, and the result is not freedom but an intensified politics of the womb. The film's Human Project, a scientific community that may be able to study Kee's fertility, is a Firestonean hope, yet the film keeps the laboratory offscreen. The cybernetic future remains a rumor; what is shown is a woman in labor on a mattress in a refugee camp.

7.3 Rich: institution and experience

Adrienne Rich's *Of Woman Born* (1976) distinguished motherhood as institution—the patriarchal regulation of women's reproductive powers—from motherhood as experience, the potential relationship of any woman to those powers and to children. The novel ends with the institution: the child is baptized and his protector crowned. The film's birth takes place outside every institution, in a borrowed room in a camp, assisted by a man who is not the father, sheltered by a woman with whom the mother shares no language. Institutions encircle the scene—the state that would seize the child, the movement that would brandish it—but the birth itself is experience. The film's only sovereign act, in the strict sense of an uncoerced decision that fixes a destiny, is the mother's naming of her child. Against Schmitt's sovereign who decides the exception, the film sets a mother who decides a name.

Against Schmitt's sovereign who decides the exception, the film sets a mother who decides a name.

7.4 Kristeva: the Virgin, women's time, the abject

Julia Kristeva's 'Stabat Mater' (1977) analyzes the Virgin Mary as the West's most elaborate construction of the maternal, a construction that sublimates and silences the actual experience of childbirth; the essay's split columns interrupt the theological analysis with the author's fragmentary account of giving birth. The film performs a similar interruption. Its iconography is insistently Marian—Kee reveals her pregnancy to Theo in a barn among cattle; she carries the child through a battlefield in the posture of a Madonna; soldiers cross themselves as she passes—yet Kee herself punctures the icon. Asked about the pregnancy, she claims to be a virgin and then laughs at her own joke. The semiotic body, in Kristeva's sense, mocks the symbolic Madonna.

'Women's Time' (1979) contrasts the linear time of history and politics with the cyclical and monumental temporalities associated with gestation, repetition and eternity. The infertile world has arrested cyclical time; the bureaucratic state still measures linear time, the time of decrees and schedules, but nothing recurs. The birth reintroduces cyclical time into dead linear time. *Powers of Horror* (1980) analyzes the abject—blood, fluids, the remainders that threaten the boundary of the self—and the film's birth, unlike the sanitized nativities of iconographic tradition, keeps the abject in view. Here the abject is not horror but life.

7.5 Irigaray: the market and the maternal genealogy

Luce Irigaray's 'Women on the Market' (1977) extended Lévi-Strauss's analysis of kinship to argue that the social order rests on the exchange of women among men, women functioning as commodities whose value is set in transactions they do not control. In the infertile world, women cease to bear exchange-value as mothers, and the single fertile woman becomes the most valuable commodity on earth. Kee is trafficked by everyone: the state would confiscate her child, the Fishes would deploy her, and Syd, the camp guard who smuggles her in, later tries to sell her for a reward. Irigaray's later work (1987) called for female genealogies, lines of descent and recognition among women that patriarchal culture suppresses. The film supplies one. Julian passes Kee into Miriam's care, Miriam into Theo's, and in the camp the protection passes to Marichka. Each woman delivers the future to the next and is lost in the passage—Julian killed, Miriam hooded and taken from the bus at the camp's gate after staging a distraction, Marichka left behind on the shore. Kee and Marichka communicate across the absence of a common language, through gesture and tone, in what Irigaray might call a relation between women and Kristeva would call the semiotic.

7.6 Ruddick and Cavarero: maternal thinking and the inclined subject

Sara Ruddick's *Maternal Thinking: Toward a Politics of Peace* (1989) argued that the practice of mothering generates a distinctive rationality organized around the preservation, growth and social acceptability of children, and that this rationality, generalized, grounds a politics of nonviolence. The Bexhill ceasefire is maternal thinking erupting into a battlefield: for a few minutes, preservative love governs armed men. Cavarero's *Inclinations* (2013), reading Leonardo's *Virgin and Child with Saint Anne*, opposes to the vertical, self-standing subject of modern philosophy the inclined posture of one who bends toward a vulnerable other. Cavarero's subject is constituted not by autonomy but by exposure. The ceasefire, as Chapter 5 argued, is a collective inclination, and it suggests the political scale of her ethics: what a mother does for a child, a battlefield can do for a moment.

7.7 Butler: grievability and kinship

Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) ask which lives are grievable and show that grievability is distributed by frames—visual, discursive, legal—that render some lives fully human and others not. The film's refugees are ungrievable within the state's frame: counted, caged, shot. The infant is absolutely grievable, and the question the film poses is whether the frame that makes her grievable can be extended to her mother and to the camp. The ceasefire answers yes for a moment; the resumption of fire answers no. Butler's *Antigone's Claim* (2000) argued that Antigone's defiance articulates forms of kinship that exceed the state's recognition; *The Force of Nonviolence* (2020) grounds nonviolence in the interdependence of lives. The film's kin—a refugee, a dying functionary, a midwife, an old cartoonist, an Eastern European stranger—form a kinship the state does not recognize, bound by care rather than blood.

7.8 Edelman, Muñoz, Halberstam: the Child and the arrivant

The sharpest queer challenge to the diptych comes from Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004), which argues that political discourse is organized by reproductive futurism, the sacralization of the figural Child as guarantor of social continuity, and that queerness names the refusal of that fantasy, the side of the death drive. *Children of Men* looks like reproductive futurism's apotheosis: without the Child, it seems to say, there is no politics. The objection must be granted for the novel, whose son is heir to Church and Crown and whose birth restores the symbolic order the Child exists to guarantee.

The film is a harder case. Its child has no known father, no nation, no church and no inheritance; she is a girl given a boy's name, the name of the dead son of a man who is not her father; she is delivered by a man who will not raise her and handed

toward a scientific community of strangers. Every link between the child and the symbolic order that Edelman's Child secures has been cut. The film's child is not the Child but what Chapter 12 calls the *arrivant*: a newcomer without lineage. José Esteban Muñoz's *Cruising Utopia* (2009) answered Edelman by recovering a queer futurity, a utopian horizon that is not yet here; Jack Halberstam's *In a Queer Time and Place* (2005) described temporalities and kinships outside the reproductive schedule. The film's Human Project, a horizon never reached, and its chosen kin belong more to that queer futurity than to reproductive futurism. Yet a concession is due: the film's affective power still depends on the sacral charge of the infant. It de-filiates the child without fully de-sacralizing her, and the residue is the price of its address to a mass audience.

7.9 Haraway: kin and companion species

Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) issued the slogan 'Make Kin Not Babies!', urging a decoupling of kinship from biological reproduction on a crowded, damaged planet. The film makes kin through a baby, but the baby is the occasion of kinship rather than its basis. Haraway's companion species are everywhere in it: dogs and cats at Jasper's house, cattle in the barn and on the pyres, a deer wandering through an abandoned school whose playground has fallen silent. The animals still reproduce; only humans are sterile. The catastrophe is a negative anthropological exception. The anthropological machine that Agamben's *The Open* (2002) describes, which produces the human by separating it from the animal, here runs in reverse: the human is distinguished from the animal by its exclusion from life's self-renewal.

7.10 Social reproduction and the last link of the care chain

Marxist feminism completes the analysis. Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) argued that the transition to capitalism required the state's appropriation of women's reproductive capacities, enforced through the witch hunts; the novel's compulsory examinations are a new enclosure of the womb. Maria Mies (1986) analyzed the international division of reproductive labor; Nancy Fraser (2016; 2022) has described a crisis of care in which capitalism devours the social reproduction on which it depends. Combined with Meillassoux's account of migrant labor and Hochschild's global care chain, these analyses reveal the diptych's deepest economic logic. A society that cannot reproduce itself must import its reproduction. James's England imports care workers; Cuarón's Britain imports, against its will, the future itself. Kee is the last link of the global care chain: the global South supplies the North not only with the labor that tends its children and elders but with the children themselves.

7.11 Comparative feminist fictions

The diptych sits within a dense field of feminist speculative fiction about reproduction and the state, and comparison sharpens its specificity. Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *Herland* (1915) imagines a parthenogenetic society of women in which motherhood is a civic religion and births are rationally limited: the utopian inverse of James's England and, in its eugenic assumptions, an uncomfortable mirror of Xan's. Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (1924) supplies the template for both versions' fugitive mothers: O-90, barred from motherhood because she falls short of the state's Maternal Norm, conceives illegally and escapes beyond the Green Wall. Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) answers infertility with theocracy: Gilead's rulers enslave fertile women as Handmaids, have them raped by Commanders in a monthly state-sanctioned ceremony, and give the children they bear to the Commanders' wives. Set beside the film, it clarifies the film's own mode of reproductive domination. Gilead conscripts the womb through sexual violence and then takes the child; Cuarón's Britain, where no fertile womb is left to conscript, concentrates its claim on the child. James's England, which surveils women without enslaving them, represents a third mode, managed despair.

Ursula K. Le Guin's 'The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas' (1973), which Le Guin traced to William James and which echoes Ivan Karamazov's refusal of any harmony purchased with a tortured child's tears, imagines a city whose happiness depends on a suffering child; the film's Britain is an Omelas whose comforts depend on cages, and Theo and Kee are the ones who walk—or row—away. Octavia E. Butler's *Dawn* (1987) makes a Black woman, Lilith Iyapo, the mother of a new hybrid species after her alien captors, the Oankali, impregnate her without her consent, and so poses the question of reproductive consent that the film leaves untouched; her *Parable of the Sower* (1993) makes a Black girl the founder of a faith directed toward the stars. Toni Morrison's *Beloved* (1987) and N. K. Jemisin's *The Fifth Season* (2015) explore, through infanticide, the extremity to which mothers are driven by regimes that would claim their children. Louise Erdrich's *Future Home of the Living God* (2017), in which a pregnant Ojibwe woman flees a state that detains pregnant women, is the film's closest contemporary analogue. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005), whose sterile clones make art to prove they have souls, offers a counterpart to the Ark of the Arts, and Leni Zumas's *Red Clocks* (2018) returns the theme to the legal regulation of pregnancy. José Saramago's *Blindness* (1995), with its quarantine camp and its unnamed doctor's wife who alone can see, belongs to the humanist rather than the feminist line, but its ethic of care under catastrophe is the film's own.

In this company the film's distinctive features stand out. It belongs with Butler, Morrison, Jemisin and Erdrich in centering a racialized woman whose reproduction the state contests, but it grants that woman far less interiority than any of them—a limitation the next chapter confronts—and it resolves her story neither by escape

inland, as in Zamyatin, nor by insurgency, as in Atwood's sequel *The Testaments* (2019), but by departure onto the sea.



CHAPTER

8

Partus Sequitur Ventrem

Race, Empire, and the Expropriated Child

8.1 The racial transvaluation

THE FILM'S MOST consequential change to the novel is racial. James's mother of the future is an English Christian; Cuarón's is a Black West African refugee. James's Sojourners labor at the margins of an England otherwise imagined as white; Cuarón's fugees fill the frame. James's cell is English; Cuarón's is multiracial and led, after Julian's death, by Luke, a Black British militant. The film's configuration—a white state, a Black mother of the future, a Black revolutionary who would appropriate her child, and a white Englishman who protects her—is at once its boldest political statement and its most vulnerable point.

8.2 Postcolonial melancholia

Paul Gilroy's *After Empire* (2004), published in the United States as *Postcolonial Melancholia*, argued that Britain's inability to mourn the loss of its empire has produced a melancholic national culture, fixated on the memory of the Second World War, that converts unworked grief into hostility toward the descendants of the colonized now living in Britain. The film's propaganda—the world has collapsed; Britain alone endures—is postcolonial melancholia in terminal form: the island imagining itself the last outpost of civilization in a barbarian world, recycling the myth of 1940 for a war against refugees. Gilroy's counter-principle was conviviality, the unremarkable everyday multiculture of urban Britain. The film glimpses it in the camp itself, where languages mingle and strangers shelter one another, and conviviality survives, as in Gilroy's account, beneath the state's melancholy.

8.3 The expropriated child

The film's plot is driven by a fear: that the state, discovering the pregnancy, would take the child from its mother and present it to the world as British. This places the film within one of the longest histories of reproductive domination in the modern world. In 1662 the colony of Virginia enacted that the children of enslaved women would follow the condition of the mother—*partus sequitur ventrem*—making the wombs of enslaved women the engine of slavery's reproduction. Hortense Spillers's 'Mama's Baby, Papa's Maybe' (1987) analyzed the consequences: the reduction of the captive body to flesh, the severance of kinship by sale, the ungendering of enslaved women, and the father's erasure. The Virginia statute was written to settle the status of children born to enslaved African women and fathered by Englishmen; many of those children were conceived through rape by enslavers, and the law made them their fathers' property rather than their heirs. Kee's child shares the structural position Spillers describes—descent reckoned through the mother alone, the father void in law—but not its history of enslavers' sexual violence; the analogy holds for the position, not for the cause. Dorothy Roberts's *Killing the Black Body* (1997) traced the continuation of state control over Black women's reproduction through coercive sterilization and punitive welfare policy, and Saidiya Hartman's *Lose Your Mother* (2007) named the afterlife of slavery, the persistence of slavery's racial calculus in the life chances of the present.

Read through this tradition, the film's structure is that of the fugitive slave narrative. Harriet Jacobs's *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl* (1861) recounts a mother's flight to protect her children from ownership; Harriet Beecher Stowe's *Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1852) supplied its period's most famous image, Eliza crossing the frozen Ohio River with her child in her arms as the slave-catchers close in, the river marking the boundary between bondage and refuge; Morrison's *Beloved*, drawing on the history of Margaret Garner, explores its extremity. Kee's flight across the sea

with her daughter, pursued by a state that would claim the child, is Eliza's crossing rewritten as thalassic natality. Once again the water is the boundary of freedom.

8.4 The statelessness of the first child

The film invites a juridical thought experiment that sharpens the point. Under the British Nationality Act 1981, in force since 1983, birth on British soil confers citizenship only if a parent is a British citizen or settled in the United Kingdom; unconditional birthright citizenship was abolished. Kee is a fugee, neither citizen nor settled. If the law of the film's Britain is the law of the present, the first child born on earth in eighteen years would not be British, and in a world in which, by the state's own account, every other state has collapsed, she would very probably be stateless. Arendt's analysis of statelessness in *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951) identified the stateless person as the one deprived of the right to have rights—the right to belong to a political community at all. The future of humanity is born without that right. The child is not merely the stranger's child; she is, juridically, a stranger herself.

The child is not merely the stranger's child; she is, juridically, a stranger herself.

8.5 Caliban's woman

Sylvia Wynter's 'Beyond Miranda's Meanings' (1990) observed that *The Tempest*, a founding drama of the colonial imagination, gives Miranda, the white woman, a place as the object of desire within the colonizer's order and gives Caliban no mate at all. The absence of Caliban's woman is the 'demonic ground' of the Western humanist system: the position it cannot represent, because representing it would disrupt the order of desire, reproduction and legitimacy on which the system rests. Wynter's 'Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom' (2003) argued that the Western figure of Man has overrepresented itself as the human as such, and that a genuinely human future requires undoing that overrepresentation. The film places Caliban's woman at the generative center. The figure the colonial imagination excluded becomes the mother of the species, and the white Englishman's role is to deliver her and die. Aimé Césaire's rewriting of Shakespeare, *Une Tempête* (1969), had already given Caliban the last word; the film gives his absent counterpart the future.

8.6 Hagar in the wilderness

The biblical figure closest to Kee is not Mary but Hagar. In Genesis 16 and 21, Hagar, an Egyptian slave, is given to Abraham by the barren Sarah to bear a child on her mistress's behalf; when Sarah conceives, Hagar and her son Ishmael are driven into the wilderness, where, near death, she is seen by God, whom she names *El Roi*, the God who sees. Paul's allegory in Galatians 4:21–31 makes Hagar the figure of bondage and Sarah of freedom, quotes Isaiah's call to the barren to sing (Isaiah 54:1), and ends with the injunction to cast out the bondwoman and her son. Delores S. Williams's *Sisters in the Wilderness* (1993) read Hagar as the paradigm of Black women's experience in America—surrogacy, sexual and economic exploitation, expulsion, survival in the wilderness—and proposed a womanist theology centered not on liberation, which God does not grant Hagar, but on survival and quality of life; Alice Walker's coinage *womanist* (1983) named the standpoint from which such readings become visible. The film reverses Paul's allegory. The bondwoman's child is the child of promise; the free woman's line has ended in sterility; and the God who sees is replaced by a camera that will not look away.

8.7 The Black Madonna and the critique of the vessel

The film's Marian iconography places Kee in the tradition of the Black Madonnas venerated at Częstochowa, Montserrat and Le Puy, and its Pietà in Bexhill extends that iconography to the grief of the camp. The iconography carries a risk. Kee speaks relatively little; her past is sketched rather than told; her interiority is largely inaccessible; the camera's identification remains with Theo. A reading in the tradition of Spillers and Hartman must ask whether the film repeats the gesture it criticizes—treating a Black woman's body as the vessel of a value not her own, the bearer of a future whose narrative belongs to someone else. The white-savior structure, in which a white protagonist redeems himself through the rescue of racialized others, is close at hand.

The film offers partial resistance. Kee is given humor, irreverence and refusal; she chooses Theo over Luke and rejects the Fishes' plan; she names her daughter; and the savior is denied his reward—he founds nothing, inherits nothing, survives nothing. But the resistance is partial. The film de-filiates the future without fully de-centering its gaze. The appropriate response is neither to dismiss the film nor to absolve it but to recognize that thalassic natality is a horizon it opens rather than a place it inhabits, and that the task of criticism—what Sharpe calls wake work and Hartman, in 'Venus in Two Acts' (2008), critical fabulation—is to imagine the interiority the film withholds.

8.8 Inverting the Great Replacement

The film can finally be read against three canonical texts of nativist apocalypse. In April 1968 Enoch Powell told a Birmingham audience that, like the Roman, he seemed to see the Tiber foaming with much blood—borrowing the Sibyl's prophecy in the sixth book of the *Aeneid* (6.86–87) to forecast civil war as the consequence of immigration. Jean Raspail's *Le Camp des saints* (1973) imagined a flotilla of a million impoverished migrants sailing for France and the collapse of a West too enfeebled to repel them; the novel, which depicts the migrants in dehumanizing racial terms, has become a canonical text of the contemporary far right, promoted in the United States by, among others, the political strategist Steve Bannon. Renaud Camus's *Le Grand Remplacement* (2011) gave its name to the white-nationalist conspiracy theory that elites are orchestrating the replacement of white Europeans by non-white immigrants. The theory has not stayed on the page. An Australian white supremacist who titled his manifesto after it murdered fifty-one worshippers at two mosques in Christchurch, New Zealand, in March 2019; a gunman who wrote of a 'Hispanic invasion' of Texas killed twenty-three people at a Walmart in El Paso that August; and a white supremacist who invoked it killed ten Black people at a supermarket in Buffalo, New York, in May 2022.

The film answers each. Rivers of blood flow at Bexhill, but they flow because the state makes war on migrants, not because migrants make war on the state; outside the film, the blood the replacement theorists prophesied has been shed by replacement theorists. The boat that arrives at the end brings not invasion but the future. And the logic of replacement becomes self-refuting: in a world in which the native population cannot reproduce at all, the only possible continuation of any nation is through the stranger, and a nativism that excludes the stranger excludes its own posterity. I call this the *Children of Men paradox*: nativist pronatalism, pursued consistently, is autoimmune. Matthew's genealogy, which runs the messianic line through Tamar, Rahab, Ruth and Bathsheba, had already encoded the paradox. The line of promise has always passed through the foreign woman.



CHAPTER

9

Fathers Without Sons

Masculinity, Mourning, and Kenosis

THE DIPTYCH IS populated by men who have lost children, cannot have them, or would use them. Its two Theos represent opposed resolutions of the crisis of paternity that infertility generalizes, and the men around them compose a typology of masculine responses to the end of the filiative contract.

9.1 The successional Theo

The novel's Theo is a historian, an aesthete and a guilty father. His arc runs from detachment through engagement to the killing of Xan and the assumption of the Coronation Ring, and its structure, as Chapter 3 showed, is that of *Totem and Taboo* and of Nemi: the son-brother kills the father-king and inherits his authority. James's masculinity is successional. Its virtue is protection, its temptation power, its telos the reconstitution of the paternal function—Lacan's Name-of-the-Father—in a world where that function had been suspended. Paternity is restored not biologically, for Theo is not the child's father, but symbolically, through the ring and the baptism.

9.2 The kenotic Theo

The film's Theo is a former activist turned ministry functionary, drinking through his days, his ears ringing after the café bomb, emotionally inert. His wound is the death of his son, Dylan, in an influenza pandemic, and his condition is what Freud called melancholia (1917): grief that cannot complete its work because the lost object has been incorporated into the ego, so that the shadow of the object falls upon the self. Melanie Klein's account of the depressive position (1940) supplies the path out: mourning is completed through reparation, the restoration in the world of what one fears one has destroyed. Theo's journey is a reparation. Having lost a child, he delivers one.

The film represents the journey as a progressive dispossession. Theo loses his car, his papers, his former partner, his friend, his protector, his shoes—he crosses the camp in flip-flops, as if on the holy ground from which Moses was told to remove his sandals (Exodus 3:5)—and finally his life. The theological name for this structure is *kenosis*, the self-emptying by which, in the hymn of Philippians 2:7, Christ 'made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant.' Gianni Vattimo (1996; 2002) read secularization itself as kenotic, a weakening of strong structures of authority, and John D. Caputo's *The Weakness of God* (2006) described the divine as a weak force, an unconditional call without sovereign power. Theo is a kenotic hero: his significance grows as his possessions diminish, and his final act is to give away what remains.

He is also a midwife. In Plato's *Theaetetus* (149a–151d) Socrates, son of the midwife Phaenarete, describes himself as a midwife of souls who is himself barren of wisdom, delivering others of what he cannot bear. Theo, father of a dead son and member of a sterile species, delivers Kee's child with his own hands. The midwives of Exodus, Shiphrah and Puah, who defied Pharaoh's order to kill the Hebrew infants, are his deeper ancestors, and the surname James gave him, Faron, carries an onomastic resonance with Pharaoh that the film transforms: the man whose name recalls the king who drowned infants becomes the one who saves an infant from the waters—Pharaoh converted into Pharaoh's daughter. The name also recalls Charon, the ferryman who carries the dead across the water for a coin. The film's Theo ferries the living, pays with his own life rather than receiving a fare, and dies before the crossing is complete. *Theo*, finally, means god: the name's bearer is a god who empties himself.

His paternity is Levinasian. In *Totality and Infinity* (1961) Levinas describes fecundity as a relation to a future that is not mine: in the child, the father is himself and other at once, possessing nothing, continued in what he cannot own. Theo's relation to Kee's daughter is fecundity without biology. His only bequest is a name, given not by him but by Kee, in which the dead son of the land survives in the living daughter of the sea. Joseph, the non-biological father who protects the mother and

child of another's begetting and leads them into exile (Matthew 1–2), is the figure the film comes closest to quoting.

I call this structure *kenotic-maieutic masculinity*: a masculinity whose telos is to deliver and disappear, to bring forth what it cannot own and to renounce the authority that protection might have conferred. It is the film's answer to the novel's successional masculinity, and its political meaning is exact. The novel's protector becomes a sovereign; the film's protector becomes a midwife and dies. The difference between them is the difference between re-filiation and de-filiation.

The novel's protector becomes a sovereign; the film's protector becomes a midwife and dies.

9.3 A typology

TABLE 2

Masculine positions in relation to the child

FIGURE	VERSION	RELATION TO THE CHILD	MODEL
Xan Lyppiatt	Novel	Would make it the legitimation of his rule	Hobbesian and Platonic sovereign
Rolf	Novel	Would claim it as the instrument of his own power	Revolutionary as would-be sovereign
Luke, the priest	Novel	Biological father, killed during the flight	Sacramental paternity
Theo Faron	Novel	Protects it, kills the sovereign, takes the ring	Successional: Nemi, *Totem and Taboo*
Nigel	Film	None; his world has abandoned the future	Nietzsche's last man; Pascal's diversion
Luke, the militant	Film	Would use it as the banner of an uprising	Instrumental revolutionary
Jasper Palmer	Film	Shelters mother and child and dies for them	Carnival father; guardian of the green world
Theo Faron	Film	Delivers it, gives it his son's name, dies	Kenotic-maieutic

9.4 Jasper and the carnival

Jasper, a retired political cartoonist living in a hidden house in the woods with his wife, Hillary, a photojournalist reduced to catatonia by state torture, is the film's carnival father. Michael Caine reportedly modeled the performance on John Lennon, and Jasper embodies the counterculture's afterlife: marijuana, irreverent jokes, Lennon's music, an anarchist's contempt for the state. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) theorized carnival as the temporary suspension of hierarchy through laughter and the grotesque body, the body that eats, drinks and breaks wind in defiance of the official order. Jasper's running joke—'pull my finger'—is the grotesque body's protest, and it is the last thing he offers the Fishes who have come to kill him. His house is what Northrop Frye (1957) called the green world of Shakespearean comedy, the forest in which the court's law is suspended and identities are remade; the film's green world, unlike Shakespeare's, is invaded and destroyed. Jasper also articulates the film's theology of chance, the subject of Chapter 11.

9.5 Revolutionary masculinity

Rolf and the film's Luke represent revolutionary masculinity in its degraded forms. Rolf confirms Robert Michels's iron law of oligarchy (1911): the organization of revolt produces new rulers. Luke confirms Fanon's warning that the leaders of liberation may become the betrayers of the liberated, and Camus's portrait of Stepan, for whom the end justifies the killing of children. Both treat the child as a means; both mirror the sovereign they oppose.

9.6 Nigel and the last man

Nigel, Theo's cousin and the minister responsible for the Ark of the Arts, is Nietzsche's last man in a well-cut suit: comfortable, cultivated, ironic, without a future. Asked how he can go on preserving works that no one will be left to see, he answers in effect that he does not think about it—Pascal's *divertissement*, the flight from the thought of death into occupation. His adolescent son, absorbed in a handheld device and apparently medicated, is the image of what Mark Fisher (2009) called depressive hedonia: not the inability to feel pleasure but the inability to do anything except pursue it. Max Weber ended *The Protestant Ethic* (1905) with a vision of 'specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart' who imagine they have attained a level of civilization never before reached. Nigel's dining room, with *Guernica* on its wall, is that vision furnished.

9.7 After paternity

The typology implies a judgment. Every masculinity organized around possession—of power, of children, of the future—fails or betrays; the masculinity that survives the film's ethical scrutiny is the one that renounces possession. Theo's death is not tragic waste but the completion of a form: the protector who refuses to become the possessor. In a cultural moment that has again begun to celebrate the patriarch as progenitor and the nation as a family to be enlarged, the film's model of masculinity—midwife, ferryman, giver of a name he does not own—is its most quietly radical proposal.



PART FIVE

Art, Faith, Hope

10 *The Ark and the Archive*

11 *Faith, Chance, and Radical Hope*



CHAPTER

10

The Ark and the Archive

Art, Witness, and the Ethics of Form

10.1 An archive without posterity

THE ARK OF the Arts occupies Battersea Power Station, the decommissioned generator on the south bank of the Thames whose chimneys Pink Floyd photographed, with an inflatable pig floating between them, for the cover of *Animals* (1977), an album that took its conceit from Orwell's *Animal Farm*. The film floats a pig there again. The conversion of a power station into a museum had a real precedent in Tate Modern, opened in 2000 in the former Bankside Power Station downstream: the energy of industrial modernity converted into the storage of its culture. Inside, Nigel has assembled rescued masterpieces—Michelangelo's *David*, damaged at the leg; Picasso's *Guernica*, hung in his dining room—while the *Pietà*, we are told, could not be saved.

Matthew Arnold defined culture in *Culture and Anarchy* (1869) as the pursuit of the best that has been thought and said; the Ark preserves the best for no one. André Malraux's *musée imaginaire* (1947) imagined a museum without walls, the totality of art made present through reproduction; the Ark is a museum without visitors. Theodor Adorno's essay on Valéry and Proust (1953) opened by observing that museum and mausoleum are connected by more than phonetic association; the Ark is a mausoleum that knows it. André Bazin traced the plastic arts to a 'mummy complex,' the impulse to preserve the living against death (1945); the Ark is the mummy complex without an afterlife. Jacques Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) argued that the archive, though it seems to concern the past, is a question of the future—a

promise and a responsibility for tomorrow—and that it is haunted by the death drive, which works to destroy the memory the archive keeps. An archive with no future reader is the death drive in a pure state: preservation as the form of destruction. Walter Benjamin's angel of history, facing the past and seeing a single catastrophe piling wreckage at his feet, has here become a curator who has made the wreckage into a collection.

10.2 From *Guernica* to Bexhill

The Ark's most important exhibit is the one it lost. The *Pietà*, Michelangelo's image of a mother holding her dead son, is absent from the collection; it reappears in Bexhill as a living woman holding the body of her son in the street. *Guernica*, Picasso's response to the destruction of the Basque town whose name it bears, bombed in April 1937 by Nazi Germany's Condor Legion and Fascist Italy's air force in support of Franco, contains at its left edge a mother howling over her dead child; it hangs as decoration in a minister's dining room and returns, in the camp, as the reality it depicted. The film stages the de-aestheticization of art: the images the Ark preserves as treasures reappear, outside its walls, as life. Adorno's dictum that to write poetry after Auschwitz is barbaric (1951) and Susan Sontag's *Regarding the Pain of Others* (2003) pose, in different registers, the question the film poses: what it means to contemplate images of suffering as art while suffering continues beyond the frame. The film's answer is to refuse the frame—to show the Pietà not in marble but in the street, where it cannot be collected.

10.3 Hillary's photographs and the civil contract

Jasper's house is hung with Hillary's photographs, the record of a career of witness, and Hillary, silenced by torture, sits among them. The photographs outlive their maker's voice. Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida* (1980) located the essence of photography in the 'that-has-been,' the certainty that the thing photographed was once there, and found in a photograph of his dead mother as a child the punctum that wounded him. Barthes, who had no children, wrote that in nursing his mother through her last illness he had in a sense engendered her, and that after her death he could only await his own total, undialectical death—a death without posterity, the infertile world's condition compressed into a single life. Sontag (1977) called every photograph a memento mori. Ariella Azoulay's *The Civil Contract of Photography* (2008) proposed that photography constitutes a political space in which the governed, the stateless among them, address one another as members of a citizenry no state confers. Hillary's photographs, and the film's own long, observant takes of the camp, extend that contract to the fugees: they are seen, which is the beginning of being received.

10.4 The long take as anti-decisionist form

The film is famous for its long takes: the opening in the café, ending in an explosion; the ambush on a country road, filmed from inside the car; the birth; the advance through Bexhill to the ceasefire, during which blood spatters the lens and remains there. Several of these apparent single takes are known to be digitally stitched composites, which sharpens rather than diminishes their meaning: the film manufactures continuity as an ethical form.

That ethical content can be specified. *Decision* derives from the Latin *decidere*, to cut off. Schmitt's sovereign is the one who cuts: who severs the exception from the norm and the enemy from the friend. Cinema's equivalent of the cut is montage, and the Soviet theory of montage, in Eisenstein's version, made the collision of shots the engine of meaning. Bazin (1958–62) defended the long take and depth of field as respecting the spatial and temporal unity of the world and its ambiguity, leaving the spectator free to look. Cuarón's long takes are *anti-decisionist form*: the camera refuses to cut, refuses to sever the protagonist from his surroundings or the foreground from the background, refuses to decide in advance what matters. It accompanies. The long take through Bexhill that culminates in the ceasefire is the natal exception's formal correlate: a suspension of the cut that coincides with a suspension of sovereign violence. The blood on the lens is an indexical trace, in Peirce's sense, of the contingency that Mary Ann Doane (2002) identified as cinema's founding fascination, and it admits the camera into the world it records. The apparatus is wounded with its subjects.

Gilles Deleuze (1985) distinguished the movement-image, in which perception extends into action, from the time-image of postwar cinema, in which characters become seers confronting situations they cannot act upon. Theo begins as a seer of this kind, paralyzed before the intolerable, and becomes an agent only when the newcomer arrives. Deleuze also wrote that modern political cinema starts from the recognition that the people are missing, and that art's task is to contribute to the invention of a people to come; with Guattari (1991) he made the summoning of a new earth and a people that does not yet exist the vocation of philosophy and art alike. *Children of Men* is the literal cinema of the missing people. Its last image is the arrival of a people to come in the person of a single child, and its last sound is that people's laughter.

Children of Men is the literal cinema of the missing people.

10.5 Acoustic eschatology

The film's sound design narrates its argument in successive acoustic states. The first is tinnitus. After the café bombing a high whine invades the soundtrack and recurs at moments of shock; Jasper, half joking, explains the ringing as the sound of cells in the ear dying, a frequency one will never hear again. Tinnitus is the sound of a sense dying, the acoustic image of the infertile world. The second is silence: Miriam recalls that despair set in as the sound of the playgrounds faded, and the abandoned school through which a deer wanders is that silence's monument. The third is the cry, the infant's voice that halts a battle. Over the closing titles comes a fourth: children's laughter, heard over a black screen on which Eliot's *Shantih shantih shantih* appears.

The music completes the design. John Tavener's *Fragments of a Prayer*, composed for the film, supplies its sacred register. The popular soundtrack is a hauntology in Fisher's sense (2014): King Crimson, Pink Floyd, John Lennon, Radiohead—the music of a counterculture the film's 2027 can only replay, because a culture without young people produces no new music. The acoustic arc runs from Eliot's whimper to the Upanishadic peace: from the sound of ending to the sound of beginning.



CHAPTER

11

Faith, Chance, and Radical Hope

11.1 James's sacramental theology

THE NOVEL IS an Anglican book in its bones. Its title comes from the Coverdale Psalter; its resistance is a primitive church; its decisive liturgy is the sacrament celebrated in abandoned places; its ending is a baptism. James's theology is incarnational: the divine meets the human in matter—bread, water, flesh—and the birth that ends the Omega is grace in the strict sense, an unmerited gift no work of science or state could produce. Augustine's *City of God* supplies the political frame. The earthly city, founded on love of self to the contempt of God and driven by the *libido dominandi*, is Xan's England; the city of God, a pilgrim community sojourning within the earthly city, is the Fishes. Augustine warned against confusing the two, against imagining that any earthly regime could embody the heavenly. The novel's ending, in which baptism and the Coronation Ring coincide, flirts with that confusion, and James knows it: the ring is a temptation, and the last pages hover between sacrament and sovereignty. But the theology is clear. The future cannot be manufactured; it can only be received.

11.2 Cuarón's secular sacramentality

The film keeps the Christian iconography and discards the doctrine. The barn, the Madonna, the procession through the battle, the soldiers' signs of the cross, the Pietà—these function, in Charles Taylor's terms (2007), within an immanent frame that remains open, cross-pressured by intimations of transcendence it neither affirms nor denies. Durkheim (1912) defined the sacred as that which is set apart and forbidden; Agamben (2005) defined profanation as the return of what was set apart to common use. The film profanes the Nativity in Agamben's precise sense. It takes the most sacred image of the Western tradition and returns it to common use—to a refugee, a camp, a battlefield, an unknown father—where it can belong to anyone. The profanation is not desecration but restitution: the Nativity was from the beginning a story of a homeless birth to a mother of uncertain reputation, followed by flight across a border. The film restores to the image the scandal that centuries of sacralization had removed.

11.3 Faith and chance

At his house in the woods Jasper offers a parable about chance and faith. Whether an event is the work of providence or of coincidence, he suggests, may be undecidable; what matters is how one answers it. The parable belongs to a philosophical lineage. Pascal's wager (1670) reasoned that, under uncertainty about God, the rational course is to live as if God exists. Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) made faith a leap beyond the ethical, held by virtue of the absurd. William James's 'The Will to Believe' (1896) argued that when an option is genuine—living, forced and momentous—and evidence cannot settle it, we are entitled to let our passional nature decide. Theo's decision to deliver Kee to the Human Project, whose existence he cannot verify, is a genuine option in James's sense: live, because it can move him; forced, because not to choose is to choose; momentous, because it is unique and irreversible.

The philosophy of moral luck adds a further dimension. Bernard Williams and Thomas Nagel (both 1976) showed that moral assessment depends on factors beyond the agent's control; Martha Nussbaum's *The Fragility of Goodness* (1986) recovered the Greek understanding of the good life's exposure to fortune. *Children of Men* is a drama of moral luck: the future depends on a chance pregnancy, a chance encounter, a chance survival. Jasper's parable converts that vulnerability into a stance. Chance becomes the medium in which faith acts.

11.4 Despair and hope

Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) distinguished despair that is ignorant of being despair from the despair of weakness, which does not will to be itself, and the despair of defiance, which wills to be itself in revolt. The diptych distributes them among its characters: Nigel's despair is unaware of itself; Theo's is the despair of weakness; Luke's is defiance.

Against despair stands a philosophy of hope in several schools. Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59) found in consciousness an anticipatory dimension, the Not-Yet, and distinguished abstract utopia, mere wishing, from concrete utopia, hope disciplined by knowledge of real possibility—*docta spes*, educated hope. Jürgen Moltmann's *Theology of Hope* (1964) made eschatology the medium of Christian faith and hope the contradiction of present reality by a promised future. Gabriel Marcel's *Homo Viator* (1944) conceived hope as relational, held for us through another. Jonathan Lear's *Radical Hope* (2006), published the same year as the film, reflected on Plenty Coups, the Crow chief who guided his people through the destruction of their way of life, and defined radical hope as hope directed toward a future goodness that exceeds one's present capacity to understand what it is. Terry Eagleton's *Hope Without Optimism* (2015) distinguished hope from the temperamental confidence that things will turn out well; Rebecca Solnit's *Hope in the Dark* (2004) located hope in the uncertainty of outcomes.

Theo's hope is radical in Lear's sense. He does not know what the Human Project is, whether it exists, or what life it could offer the child; he hopes for a good he cannot conceive and acts on that hope at the cost of everything. His hope is also Marcellian: it is held for another, a child not his own, and the 'us' for whom he hopes is a community that does not yet exist. And it is concrete in Bloch's sense: the ship is real, the buoy is real, the promise was made. The title of the film's companion documentary, *The Possibility of Hope*, states the film's thesis precisely: not the certainty of salvation but its possibility.

11.5 Weak messianism

Benjamin's second thesis speaks of a weak messianic power with which each generation is endowed. Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) distinguished messianism, the expectation of a determinate redeemer, from messianicity, a structural openness to the coming of the other—the *arrivant*—without content or guarantee. Agamben's *The Time That Remains* (2000), reading Paul, defined messianic time as the time that time takes to come to an end, a contracted time that transforms every moment; Jacob Taubes's *The Political Theology of Paul* (1993) read Paul as a revolutionary of the weak against Roman sovereignty. Paul himself wrote that the whole creation groans and travails in pain together until now (Romans 8:22)—creation figured as a woman in labor—and that God has chosen the weak things of the world to confound the mighty (1 Corinthians 1:27). The infant is the weak force par excellence: it commands nothing, threatens nothing, decides nothing, and yet halts an army. The film's messianism is weak in every one of these senses. Its redeemer is a newborn girl; its redemption is a ceasefire that ends; its kingdom is a ship in fog.

11.6 *Shantih* and the thunder

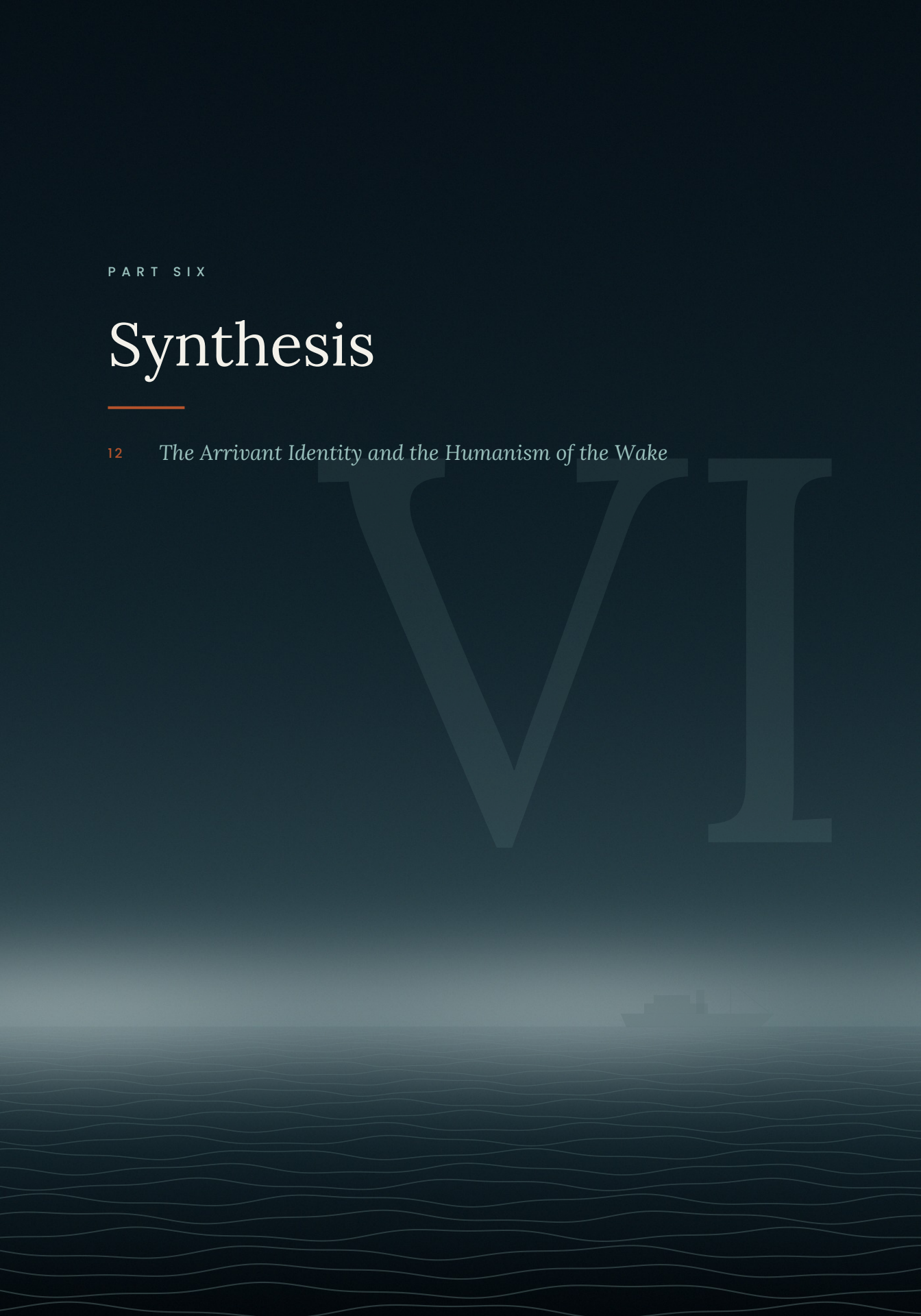
The Waste Land closes by translating the voice of the thunder from the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad (5.2), in which the creator utters the syllable *Da* to gods, humans and demons, who hear in it three commands: *damyata*, control yourselves; *datta*, give; *dayadhvam*, be compassionate. Eliot glossed the closing *Shantih* in his notes as an equivalent of 'the peace which passeth understanding' (Philippians 4:7). The film's ethics can be read in the thunder's triad. *Datta*: Jasper, Miriam, Marichka and Theo give—shelter, distraction, guidance, life. *Dayadhvam*: compassion crosses language between Kee and Marichka and crosses the lines of battle in the ceasefire. *Damyata*: the soldiers' restraint is self-control in its political form. The final *Shantih* is a peace that passes understanding in the literal sense: it is heard as children's laughter over a black screen, a sound without an image, a meaning without an explanation.

There is a further convergence. The Epistle to the Philippians, which supplies Eliot's gloss on *Shantih*, also contains the hymn of kenosis (Philippians 2:5–11) that names Theo's arc. The film's theology is, in short, Philippian: a self-emptying that issues in a peace beyond understanding.

PART SIX

Synthesis

12 *The Arrivant Identity and the Humanism of the Wake*



CHAPTER

12

The Arrivant Identity and the Humanism of the Wake

THE PRECEDING CHAPTERS have assembled the elements of an argument; this chapter states it. It asks what becomes of the major traditions of humanism when posterity is subtracted, formulates the arrivant identity and the natal criterion of legitimacy that follows from it, sets out the humanism of the wake in seven theses, and answers the strongest objections.

12.1 Humanisms under subtraction

Renaissance humanism, in Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486), located human dignity in the absence of a fixed nature: the human is the chameleon, the being that fashions itself. Self-fashioning is a project, and projects require a future; in the infertile world the chameleon has nowhere to go. Montaigne's humanism, which held that to philosophize is to learn to die, fares better: the diptych is full of people learning to die, and the Quietus is Montaigne turned into policy. Kant grounds dignity in rational autonomy, the capacity to give oneself the moral law; autonomy survives the infertile world but becomes empty, a form without a world to legislate for. Sartre's 'Existentialism Is a Humanism' (1946) defined the human by its project: existence precedes essence, and the human is nothing other than what it makes of itself by projecting itself toward the future. The film's Human Project is Sartre's *projet* turned into an institution, the last project of a species whose individual projects have lost their point. Camus's humanism—the rebel's 'I revolt, therefore we exist,' Rieux's common decency in *The Plague* (1947)—survives most robustly, because it never depended on the future: it is the humanism of those who act well without hope of victory, and Theo, Miriam and Marichka belong to it.

The anti-humanist critique finds its measure in the diptych too. Heidegger's 'Letter on Humanism' (1947) attacked humanism as metaphysics; Althusser treated 'man' as an ideological effect; Foucault ended *The Order of Things* (1966) by wagering that man, a recent invention, might be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. The film's last sequence takes place at the edge of the sea, where the face is drawn again. John Gray, one of the voices in Cuarón's companion documentary, argued in *Straw Dogs* (2002) that humanism is a Christian residue and progress a myth. The film half vindicates him: its world has no progress, and its humanism is unmistakably shaped by Christian forms. But the half it does not vindicate is decisive: in the absence of progress, care persists.

The posthumanist and decolonial critiques press further. Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013) proposed a zoe-centered egalitarianism that affirms life's generative force beyond the human, reversing Agamben's bare life into an affirmative vitality; the film's transfiguration of the camp's bare life into the source of the future is a Braidottian reversal. Fanon closed *The Wretched of the Earth* by calling for a new humanism that would not repeat Europe's; Césaire (1950) exposed European humanism as a pseudo-humanism that had tolerated massacre, forced labor and racial rule in the colonies and recoiled only when Nazism turned those methods on Europeans; Wynter (2003) called for a conception of the human after Man. Edward Said's *Humanism and Democratic Criticism* (2004) defended a humanism of critique and exile; Levinas's *Humanism of the Other* (1972) grounded humanism in responsibility for the other rather than in the autonomy of the self. Vasily

Grossman's *Life and Fate* (1980) gave that responsibility its most moving form in Ikonnikov's meditation on senseless kindness, the small, unideological acts of goodness that survive every system; Primo Levi's *The Drowned and the Saved* (1986), whose title the film's ending enacts, described the gray zone of compromise in which several of the film's helpers—Syd above all—move.

From this survey a conclusion emerges. The humanisms that collapse under the subtraction of posterity are those grounded in self-fashioning, progress and the project; those that survive are grounded in reception, vulnerability and care. The humanism the diptych requires is of the second kind.

12.2 The arrivant identity

Arendt called human beings newcomers: each is born into a world that precedes it, a stranger whom the world must receive. In 'We Refugees' (1943), writing from her own statelessness, she argued that refugees driven from country to country represent the vanguard of their peoples. Agamben's essay of the same title (1995) radicalized the point: the nation-state rests on the nexus between nativity and nationality—*natio* derives from *nasci*, to be born—and the refugee, by breaking that nexus, exposes the fiction on which the state is founded. Derrida's *Aporias* (1993) described the absolute *arrivant*, who arrives without name, identity or invitation, whose coming surprises the host and unsettles the host's mastery of the home. Kant grounded the right of hospitality in the shared surface of the earth. Levinas, following the prophets, made the stranger, the orphan and the widow the faces through which the ethical command addresses us; the law of Deuteronomy measures justice by the treatment of the *ger*, the *yatom* and the *almanah* (Deuteronomy 10:18; 24:17), and Exodus grounds the command not to oppress the stranger in the memory 'for ye were strangers in the land of Egypt' (Exodus 22:21).

From these sources I derive the *arrivant identity*: the newborn and the refugee occupy, at the level of political ontology, a single position. Both arrive without consent or credentials. Both depend absolutely on reception. Both disclose, by their arrival, the criteria by which the polity admits or excludes. Both carry the polity's future—the newborn by definition, the refugee increasingly in societies whose native populations no longer replace themselves. Both are, until received, without a world. The difference between them is one of degree, not of kind: the refugee is a newcomer who has already been born once and has lost the world into which she was first received.

The film's master stroke is to make the two one person. Kee is a refugee; her daughter is a newborn and, juridically, a refugee too. The two forms of arrival that modern politics keeps in separate compartments—natality policy and migration policy, family law and asylum law, the maternity ward and the detention center—are

fused in a single body. Together Kee and her child occupy all three Deuteronomic positions: the stranger, the fatherless and, after Theo's death, the bereaved.

12.3 The natal criterion of legitimacy

From the arrivant identity follows a criterion of political legitimacy. A polity is legitimate to the degree that it can receive the newcomer as newcomer—without appropriating it, abandoning it or destroying it. The criterion supplements, rather than replaces, the consent-based criteria of the social-contract tradition, which measure legitimacy by the agreement of those already present; the natal criterion measures it by the reception of those not yet present, or present without standing. John Rawls's original position (1971), in which principles of justice are chosen behind a veil of ignorance about one's place in society, is in effect a hypothetical prenatal standpoint, and his just savings principle extended it across generations. The natal criterion makes the newcomer's standpoint actual rather than hypothetical.

Five consequences follow. First, asylum is not a humanitarian exception to sovereignty but the paradigm of the political: birth is the first asylum, the reception into a world not one's own that every human being has undergone, and political community is the generalization of that reception. Winnicott's remark that there is no such thing as a baby—only a baby and someone caring for it—names the holding environment that is the proto-political form. Second, the jurisprudence of citizenship by birthplace and by descent, *jus soli* and *jus sanguinis*, is revealed as a jurisprudence of natality, a set of answers to the question of how a polity receives its newcomers. Third, nativist pronatalism—encouraging native births while excluding foreign arrivals—is autoimmune by the diptych's logic: it divides the arrivant identity against itself, welcoming one form of arrival while refusing the other, and in a world of declining fertility it refuses its own future. Fourth, obligations to future generations and obligations to present strangers are one obligation: the ethics of Parfit and Jonas and the ethics of Arendt and Derrida converge on the arrivant. Fifth, the measure of a polity is the condition of its camps.

Birth is the first asylum.

12.4 The humanism of the wake: seven theses

I Natality, not autonomy, grounds dignity. The human being is owed respect not because it can give itself the law but because it is a beginning—*initium ut esset*—that no one can repeat.

II The human is received before it is self-made. Every human life begins in dependence on a reception it did not choose and could not deserve: Winnicott's holding, Cavarero's inclination, Levinas's face, the newborn's 'ought' in Jonas. Self-fashioning is a late and fragile achievement built on that reception.

III The paradigmatic human is the arrivant. The newborn and the refugee are not marginal cases of the human but its paradigm, because they display without disguise the condition of every human being: to arrive without credentials and to depend on being received.

IV Kinship is made, not inherited. Lineage, nation and blood are forms kinship takes, not its essence. The Matthean genealogy through foreign women, Ruth's vow to Naomi (Ruth 1:16), Levinas's fecundity without possession, Haraway's kin, and Theo's gift of a dead son's name to another man's daughter show that kinship is an act of reception.

V The decisive political event is destituent. The natal exception suspends sovereign violence without founding a new sovereignty. Politics in its highest form is not the decision but the interruption of the decision by the newcomer.

VI The space of the newcomer is a commons, figured as the sea. Because sovereignty is constituted by the appropriation of land, the newcomer can be received without appropriation only in a commons. The sea is that commons's figure and also its warning: a commons becomes a grave when the land extends its reach over it.

VII Hope is care for a future one will not inhabit. Theo dies before the ship arrives. The humanism of the wake does not promise its practitioners that they will see the future they serve; it asks them to keep vigil over the dead, to follow the track of the living, and to wake.

The name of this humanism comes from Sharpe's triple sense of the wake. It is a humanism of vigil, because it begins in mourning—for Dylan, Julian, Jasper, Miriam, Theo and the uncounted dead of the camp. It is a humanism of the track, because it follows the passage of the newcomer across the water without claiming the destination. And it is a humanism of wakefulness, because it requires waking from the dream of Man: the sovereign, self-fashioning, possessive subject whose world ended in the diptych's sterility.

12.5 Objections and replies

THE OBJECTION FROM REPRODUCTIVE FUTURISM Edelman would object that grounding dignity in natality renews the sacralization of the Child. The reply is that the arrivant is not the Child. The humanism of the wake is indifferent to biological reproduction as such; it concerns reception, and the adult refugee is as fully an arrivant as the infant. It assigns no privilege to lineage, nation or the heteronormative family, and it is compatible with—indeed, it requires—the queer and chosen kinships Muñoz and Halberstam describe.

THE ANTINATALIST OBJECTION Benatar would object that celebrating birth into a ruined world compounds a harm. The reply is that the natal criterion makes no claim about whether coming into existence benefits the one who comes. It is an ethics of the arrived, not a valuation of procreation: given that newcomers arrive, it specifies what is owed to them.

THE OBJECTION FROM THE WHITE SAVIOR The humanism of the wake has been illustrated by a white Englishman's sacrifice for a Black African woman. The reply concedes the objection's force. Kenotic-maieutic masculinity structurally subtracts the savior—he dies, inherits nothing, founds nothing—but the film's point of view remains his. The humanism of the wake therefore requires a critical practice that completes what the film leaves incomplete: the imagination of Kee's interiority, in the spirit of Hartman's critical fabulation.

THE OBJECTION FROM CRYPTO-THEOLOGY The humanism of the wake might seem a secularized Christianity. The reply is twofold. First, the diptych's religious figures are profaned in Agamben's sense—returned to common use—rather than reinstated; Arendt herself read the Nativity as a political rather than a dogmatic truth. Second, if Schmitt was right that modern political concepts are secularized theological ones, the question is not whether to have a political theology but which: the sovereign exception or the natal one.

THE OBJECTION FROM THALASSIC ROMANTICISM The sea is a graveyard. The reply is that the humanism of the wake insists on it. Thalassic natality is not a celebration of the ocean but a demand that the commons be made a place of reception rather than

death, and it takes its name from a word that, in Sharpe's usage, is inseparable from the Middle Passage.

THE COMMUNITARIAN OBJECTION Michael Walzer's *Spheres of Justice* (1983) and David Miller's *Strangers in Our Midst* (2016) defend the right of political communities to determine their membership, without which, they argue, the distinctiveness and solidarity of communities cannot be sustained. The natal criterion does not deny that communities may regulate admission; it is a criterion of legitimacy, not an admissions quota. But it is not silent on policy. It counts against a polity's legitimacy whenever arrivals are returned to places where they face persecution (refoulement, prohibited by Article 33 of the 1951 Refugee Convention), detained indefinitely or as a deterrent, left to drown or pushed back at sea, removed to third countries without examination of their claims, or, in the case of children born on the territory, left without any nationality. The United Kingdom's Supreme Court applied the first of these tests in November 2023, when it held the government's Rwanda scheme unlawful because of the risk of refoulement. The criterion also observes that every bounded community already practices unconditional reception for one class of arrivals, its newborns. The question it puts to the communitarian is whether the logic by which a community receives its children can be wholly sealed off from the logic by which it receives strangers. The diptych's answer is that, in a world of falling fertility, it cannot.

THE OBJECTION FROM APPROPRIATION Nativist pronatalists—governments that pair incentives for native births with hostility to immigration, as Hungary's has, and the movements that champion them—might enlist the film as an allegory of demographic decline. The reply is that the film forbids it. Its future is the migrant's child, and any pronatalism that refuses the stranger reproduces the regime the film depicts.

CONCLUSION

Come Again

THE TITLE OF James's novel is an imperative, and its grammar is double. The Coverdale Psalter's 'Come again, ye children of men' and the Authorized Version's 'Return, ye children of men' translate a single Hebrew verb, *shuvu*, whose range runs from return to repentance; the Vulgate's *convertimini* inclines toward conversion. Psalm 90 holds both senses in one breath: the God who turns mortals back to dust also calls them to come again. The diptych distributes the senses between its protagonist and its child. Theo returns—converts, repents, is turned from melancholy to action—and the child comes. Conversion and arrival are the two movements of the natal exception, the one undergone by those who receive, the other by the one received.

The psalm also names its addressees. *Bene adam*, the children of the earthling, are the offspring of the creature formed from *adamah*, the soil. Athenian civic ideology, as Nicole Loraux showed in *The Children of Athena* (1981), founded citizenship on autochthony, the myth that the citizens' ancestors were born from the earth itself, and used the myth to exclude women and foreigners from the city. Every nativism is an autochthony. The film's final image answers both the psalm's anthropology and Athens's. Its child is not born of the soil but carried off it; her name, through the Welsh Dylan, means son of the wave. The children of the earth, the film proposes, must become children of the sea—not because the earth is evil but because the land has been appropriated by the sovereign exception, and the newcomer can be received only where appropriation ends.

Ecclesiastes gives the classical statement of the filiative contract: 'One generation passeth away, and another generation cometh: but the earth abideth for ever' (Ecclesiastes 1:4). The infertile world falsifies the first clause; the film restores it, but relocates the third. It is no longer the earth that abides but the sea that carries—the sea into which, as Qoheleth also observed, all the rivers run, and which is never full (1:7).

The Apocalypse, finally, ends not with a disclosure but with an invitation: 'And the Spirit and the bride say, Come. And let him that heareth say, Come' (Revelation 22:17). Derrida's 'Of an Apocalyptic Tone Recently Adopted in Philosophy' (1983) read that verse as the apocalypse's deepest secret: beneath the tones of revelation, ending and

judgment lies a 'Come' addressed to one who arrives without its being determined who that will be. *Children of Men* is apocalyptic in this precise sense. It unveils nothing about the end; it addresses the one who comes.

This dissertation has argued that the diptych, read across the gap between its two versions, constitutes a sustained inquiry into what a world owes to those who arrive in it. James's novel answers that the newcomer must be received into a lineage—Church, Crown, the father's name—and that the future can be secured by restoring the filiative contract through grace and succession. Cuarón's film answers that the newcomer can be received only by those willing to renounce possession of it, and only in a space beyond the land's law; that the miracle which halts sovereign violence founds nothing and must be carried onward; that the stranger and the child are one figure; and that the humanism adequate to an age of falling fertility, hardening borders and drowning seas is one that keeps vigil over the dead, follows the track of the living, and wakes.

The film ends in fog. The ship appears; the man who brought them there is dead; the mother speaks his name; the screen goes black; children laugh. Whether the Human Project exists, whether the child will thrive, whether humanity will be renewed, the film does not say. It says only that a world that has learned to say *Come* to the stranger has already said it to the child, and that the reverse is equally true. Come again, ye children of men: not back to the land from which you were taken, but onward, across the water, toward those who will have to receive you.

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INDEX TERMS

Keywords

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Come again, ye children of men.

PSALM 90:3

